

Wh-questions in Tagalog: Pseudo-Clefts or *Wh*-Movement?

Joseph A. Sabbagh
Dept. of Linguistics & TESOL, UT Arlington

Abstract

Many, though by no means all, (Western) Austronesian languages are claimed to form *wh*-questions using a bi-clausal pseudo-cleft structure, rather than deriving them by an operation of *wh*-movement. To date, this seems to be mostly widely accepted analysis for interrogative questions in Tagalog, more specifically for questions involving a DP argument (*ano* ‘what’, *sino* ‘who’) (Aldridge 2002, 2004, 2009). It is likewise argued to be the basis for the structure of *wh*-questions in other Austronesian languages such as Malagasy (Potsdam 2016, 2017; Paul 2001; Paul & Potsdam 2012; Potsdam & Polinsky 2011). In this paper, I present several arguments that a pseudo-cleft analysis is neither the more direct nor correct analysis for *wh*-questions in Tagalog. Some of these arguments may be viewed as equivocal, pointing merely to a structural ambiguity. I attempt, therefore, to make a more persuasive argument that a pseudo-cleft analysis based on the incompatibility of the analysis with the standard analysis of the semantics of *wh*-questions. In order to generate an appropriate logical form for questions given a pseudo-cleft structure, the *wh*-phrase that functions as a predicate must undergo movement (namely, predicate raising). Raising of a predicate phrase, though an attested option for deriving verb initial word order in at least some verb initial languages (Clemens & Polinsky 2018, and references therein) does not seem to be an available operation for Tagalog, and hence – not available for generating a logical form for *wh*-questions. If this reasoning is sound, then what opens up is a possible explanation for a hypothesized correlation between languages that use vP-fronting to derive word order and also use a pseudo-cleft structure for forming *wh*-questions (Potsdam 2017, Oda 2002, 2005). In particular, the conclusion reached is that a language will be able to utilize a pseudo-cleft for *wh*-questions *if and only if* there is also evidence within the language for a process that involves movement of a predicate phrase. Since evidence for predicate raising is lacking in Tagalog, it is also concluded that the pseudo-cleft strategy for forming *wh*-questions is unavailable.

Keywords: Tagalog, *Wh*-questions, Pseudo-cleft, *Wh*-movement, verb initial word order

1 Introduction

This article is concerned with the structure of interrogatives (*wh*-questions), primarily focussed on Tagalog. For questions involving a DP argument, the standard analysis of *wh*-questions for Tagalog as well as other related Austronesian languages¹ is that they take the form of a pseudo-cleft, as schematized in (2) for a question like (1).

- (1) Sino ang bumili ng sapatos?
 who AV.PERF.buy DEP shoes
 ‘Who bought shoes?’
- (2) [TP [PredP Who] [DP D [CP *Op t* bought shoes]]]

According to this analysis, the *wh*-phrase is the predicate of a main clause, and the ‘remainder’ of the question is a subject with the syntax of a free relative clause. *Wh*-questions are thus roughly equivalent to specificational copula clauses (see, e.g., Higgins 1979, Akmajian 1979, Moro 1997, Mikkelsen 2005), which may be paraphrased as something like (*The one*) *who bought the shoes is who?*. This analysis of *wh*-questions is advocated for Tagalog by, among others, Aldridge (2002, 2004, 2009), Richards (1998), Mercado (2004), Gerasimova & Sells (2008), and Hsieh (2020, Ch. 4). This analysis contrasts with the way that questions are typically held to be formed in other languages, namely, by *wh*-movement of a *wh*-phrase to an ($\bar{A}$ -)position located in the left-periphery of the clause (e.g., Spec, CP). Tagalog is also claimed to employ this strategy. In particular, the pseudo-cleft analysis has been proposed for questions involving a (DP) argument (*ano* ‘what’ or *sino* ‘who’), whereas *wh*-movement is claimed to be the strategy used to form questions for non-DP arguments and adjuncts.

The question of why questions based on DP arguments are formed using a pseudo-cleft structure, while those involving non-DP arguments or adjuncts are formed by *wh*-movement, has never been fully addressed in the existing literature. Given that the *wh*-phrase is a predicate in the pseudo-cleft structure proposed for DP arguments, one might attribute the difference to the (in)ability of phrases of certain types to be function syntactically and semantically as predicates: DP’s like *ano* (‘what’) and *sino* (‘who’) may function as predicates, but a locative or reason *wh*-phrase, as in the examples in (3) cannot.

¹See, for instance Georgopolous 1991 on Palauan; Jensen 2014 on Jarai; Cole & Harmon 1998, 2000, Cole, Harmon & Aman on Malay; Paul & Postdam 2008 on Malagasy; Aldridge 2002 on Seediq; Wilson-Sturman 2014 on Marshalese. Other Austronesian languages are argued to form *wh*-questions by *wh*-movement. These include Chamorro (Chung 1998, 2009), Selayarese (Finer 1997), and Mandar (Brodin 2020).

- (3) a. Bakit hindi mo ako hinintay?
 why not 2SG(DEP) 1SG(UNM) PV.PERF.wait
 ‘Why didn’t you wait for me?’
 b. Saan mo iyan na-basa?
 where 2SG(DEP) that PV.PERF.read
 ‘Where did you read that?’

In this paper, I argue that *wh*-questions based on DP arguments, like (1), are not exclusively (or possibly ever) formed using a pseudo-cleft strategy. Instead, the unmarked strategy for the syntax of *wh*-questions in the language involves *wh*-movement. There are, therefore, no major structural difference between *wh*-questions like (1) and (3) on this analysis and therefore no need to introduce anything into the grammar to explain a structural difference. The argument for this is divided into two parts. After presenting a very brief introduction to Tagalog in Section 2, I present five arguments in Section 3 involving grammatical contexts where a pseudo-cleft analysis makes incorrect predictions. These argument are primarily based on certain language internal grammatical patterns, and some of these arguments (arguably) merely demonstrate that *some wh*-questions involving DP arguments are derived by *wh*-movement, but do not wholesale preclude a pseudo-cleft analysis for questions globally.

Section 4 of this paper makes a stronger claim: The pseudo-cleft analysis of questions is unlikely to be available at all. The argument for this stronger claim is based on the semantics of *wh*-questions and can be summarized as follows: To derive an appropriate logical form for questions based on a pseudo-cleft structure, the *wh*-phrase (=the predicate of the copular clause that is the basis of the pseudo-cleft structure) must undergo *wh*-movement. Movement of a predicate phrase (=PredP), though available in some languages and the likely means for deriving verb initial word order in those languages, is not available in Tagalog. Since PredP movement is absent in Tagalog, as I shall argue, the means to derive an appropriate logical form for questions is also precluded given the pseudo-cleft analysis. This argument is related to a hypothesis put forward in Oda (2002, 2005), and further developed by Potsdam (2009) (see also, Polinsky & Potsdam 2011), according to which a pseudo-cleft structure for *wh*-questions is linked to the availability of a mechanisms that raises the predicate phrase (PredP), which is used – for instance – as the means for deriving verb initial word order. I will present a case that verb initial word order is not derived by PredP raising, making the mechanism for raising a *wh*-phrase in the context of a pseudo-cleft analysis dubious. Even were it not for this issue, I argue that there are additional semantic reasons for rejecting the pseudo-cleft analysis.

If the conclusions reached are sound, then the case is made that a pseudo-cleft analysis for *wh*-questions must be limited cross-linguistically. This has been previously hypothesized, by Oda (2002, 2005) who frames the hypothesis in terms of the following generalization.

- (4) Oda’s Generalization (2002, 2005):
 If a languages uses VP raising to derive V1 word order, then it will have available a cleft to form *wh*-questions.

The arguments and conclusions of this paper suggest a stronger version of this generalization, in which the generalization is stated as a bi-directional:

- (5) Oda’s Generalization (*bi-directional*):
 A language will have available a cleft to form *wh*-questions if and only if it uses VP raising (to derive V1 word order).

Section 4 provides the semantic basis for Oda’s generalization and for this stronger form of it. This paper therefore adds to the ongoing and open discussion of the different routes to deriving verb initial word order (see, e.g., the volume of papers in Carnie et. al. 2000, and Carnie et. al 2001, as well as Clemens & Polinsky 2017), a topic of interest in its own right, and on the different routes languages may take to form *wh*-questions, and how these two strands might be related (see, e.g., Potsdam & Polinsky 2011).

2 Language Background

Tagalog (Filipino) is a Western-Austronesian language spoken throughout the Philippines where it is the national language, as well as throughout the US, where it is the second most spoken Asian language in the country. (Elicited data in this paper were collected in the US.) Word order is verb initial, but free with respect to the order of arguments and adjuncts post-verbally. There is no copula verb, and so predicates may belong to any category type in addition to VP (AP, DP, or PP (for locatives)). In general, for clauses whose predicate is a verb, one argument of the verb has a privileged status over others, and this argument has been variously referred to as the SUBJECT, TOPIC, or PIVOT. I will refer to it throughout this article as the subject. The subject is marked by *ang* (for common nouns) or *si* (for proper names), and its thematic role or Case-value is ‘flagged’ by the morphology of the verb. The verbal morphology is often referred to as ‘ACTOR TOPIC/VOICE (=AV)’ (when an agent is the subject), ‘PATIENT/UNDERGOER TOPIC/VOICE (=PV)’ (when a theme or patient argument is the subject). Consider the following examples, illustrating these two ‘voices’.

- (6) Nag-bigay ng regalo si Maria sa bata’.
 PERF.AV-give DEP gift UNM Maria OBL child
 ‘Maria gave a gift to the child.’
- (7) I-binigay ang regalo ni Maria sa bata’.
 PV-PERF.give UNM gift DEP Maria OBL child
 ‘Maria gave the gift to the child.’

More distant arguments (e.g., indirect objects) as well as at least certain adjuncts may be selected as subjects in what is often referred to as the ‘{GOAL/DIRECTIONAL, BENEFACTIVE, LOCATIVE, CIRCUMSTANTIAL} VOICE’. In the glossing throughout, I will use the gloss that names the thematic role most directly corresponding to the theta-role of the argument that is promoted to subject status. For instance, in example (8) below this is the goal argument,

hence the glossing GV on the verbal affix.²

- (8) *Binigy-an ng regalo ni Maria ang bata*’.
 PERF.give-GV DEP gift DEP Maria UNM child.
 ‘Maria gave a/the gift to the child.’

Finally, Tagalog contrasts three cases, which I will refer to in this paper as the UNMARKED (UNM) ($\approx$ nominative), DEPENDENT (DEP) ($\approx$ accusative or genitive), and OBLIQUE (OBL), and these are summarized in (9).

- (9) *Tagalog Case*:

	UNMARKED	DEPENDENT	OBLIQUE
NAME	<i>si</i>	<i>ni</i>	<i>kay</i>
COMMON N.	<i>ang</i>	<i>ng</i> (= [nang])	<i>sa</i>

Crucially, the UNMARKED case is the case that is typically associated with the selected subject of the clause, and – for our purposes – it is the main one to occasionally pay attention to. The choice of how these cases are referred to and glossed reflects an assumption that the morphological cases in Tagalog flow from a Dependent Case Theory of the sort proposed by Marantz (1990) (see also, McFadden 2004; Bobaljik 2008; and Baker & Vinakurova 2010). However, nothing particularly important hinges on this for the present work, and it is adopted here primarily to streamline the glossing of case.³

For additional details relating to topics raised in this brief background to the language, the reader is referred to: Schachter (1976, 1996); Guilfoyle, Hung, & Travis (1992); Kroeger (1993); Richards (1998); Rackowski (2002); Aldridge (2002); Chen (2025); and Hsieh (2020).

3 Arguments for *Wh*-Movement

This section offers five arguments that at least some *wh*-questions can, or even must, be derived by *wh*-movement and that a pseudo-cleft analysis, if it is available at all, must have a restricted distribution.

²Rackowski (2002) analyzes this morphology as Case agreement (cf. Chung 1994, 1998). I have opted to use the more wide-spread voice-based terms like AGENT/PATIENT-VOICE primarily for convenience. This terminology, it should be noted, is for descriptive purposes only.

³In particular, what I call the DEP(ENDENT) case is sometimes claimed to realize either an accusative or a genitive case. As this leads to a certain amount of complexity in the glossing, I use the DEP gloss as a (possible) cover for the case or cases realized as *ng/ni* and the related pronominal forms.

3.1 Locative and Predicate Locatives

In Tagalog, the predicate (phrase) may belong to any category type: VP and AP as well as DP and locative PPs. There is no copula.⁴ As non-verbal predicates, APs and DPs receive no special marking. However, when a locative is a predicate, it must be introduced by the generalized preposition *sa* prefixed by *na-*. Consider the following examples.⁵

- (10) a. Nasa panganib si Juan.
PRED.LOC danger UNM Juan
'Juan is in danger.'
- b. Naroon ang tatlong anak ni Zeruias.
PRED.there UNM three.LK child DEP Zeruias
'Zurias' three children were there.'
(<https://www.bible.com/bible/144/2SA.2.18.MBB05>)

Locatives without the prefix *na-* cannot function as predicates. This point is illustrated by the ungrammaticality of sentence (11), which may be compared to sentence (10a).

- (11) *Sa panganib si Juan.
LOC danger UNM Juan
(‘Juan is in danger.’)

In copular constructions where a locative PP functions as a predicate, the locative may be questioned. In such cases, the prefix *na-* is obligatory.

- (12) *(Na)saan ang mga estudyante?
PRED.where UNM PL student
'Where are the students?'

If interrogatives generally take the form of pseudo-cleft with the *wh*-phrase functioning as a predicate, then we would expect a questioned locative to be prefixed by *na-* indicating its status as a predicate. This is not what we find, however. When a locative argument is questioned, a bare locative *wh*-word *saan* ('where'), without the *na-* prefix is used. Adding the prefix to it results in ungrammaticality.

- (13) (*Na)saan ka naka-kita ng itlog?
(PRED).where 2SG(UNM) AV.PERF-find DEP egg
'Where did you find an egg?'

⁴Though see Richards 2009 on the difference between a null copula and a copula that surfaces as the verb *maging* 'to be(come)'.

⁵Data for this article come from one or two sources: Elicitation with four native speakers, or data culled from sources on the web or other written sources. To ensure accuracy of web-data, examples were shown to native speaker consultants to determine naturalness. A URL is provided for all examples found through a web-based search. The following language-specific glossing used is as follows: AV 'actor voice', PV 'patient voice', LK 'linker', (IM)PERF '(im)perfective'. Glossing conventions for other languages can be found in the sources provided.

Given that the locative here is not prefixed by *na-*, it follows that *wh*-questions formed by questioning a locative argument (or adjunct) are not predicates and therefore that such interrogatives do not have the structure of a pseudo-cleft. Put in other words, at the very least we may conclude that the grammatical version of (13) is not amenable to an analysis involving a pseudo-cleft structure.

One might reasonably object to the argument being made here by pointing out that it is a well-known fact that locatives (and other non-DPs, including adjuncts) do not utilize a pseudo-cleft structure when questioned. Instead, it is typically assumed that when a phrase such as a locative (whether it is an argument or an adjunct) is questioned, the locative is directly fronted to Spec, CP via *wh*-movement (Richards 1998, Aldridge 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005, Hsieh 2020). One piece of evidence for this comes from the observation that when locative or other non-DPs are questioned, the particle *ang*, which is homophonous with the case marker for subjects (=UNM), does not surface as it does when a DP argument is questioned. Sentence (14), for instance, is ungrammatical when *ang* is present (see Section 3.5 for additional details on the particle *ang*).

- (14) Saan (*ang) in-ilagay ni Juan ang matrilyo?
 where PV.IMPERF-put DEP Juan UNM hammer
 ‘Where did Juan put the hammer.’

If the pseudo-cleft strategy were even possible here, however, we might expect a sentence like (15) to be more robust.

- (15) ??Nasaan ang in-iligay ni Juan ang matrilyo?
 PRED.LOC PV.IMPERF-put DEP Juan UNM hammer
 (‘Where did Juan put the hammer?’;
 lit. ‘The place where Juan put the hammer is where?’)

Of the speakers consulted (4 total), all indicated a strong preference for the grammatical version of sentence (14) compared to sentence (15), and 2/4 went as far as to judge sentence (15) unacceptable. In Section 4.4 I will offer a possible explanation for why (15) is ungrammatical/dispreferred, but for now the contrast between (14) and (15) is sufficient to demonstrate, at the very least, that the use of a pseudo-cleft structure must be restricted to the extent that it is available at all for a syntactic analysis of questions. That is, even when a locative is properly prefixed to indicate its status as a predicate – a condition that would presumably be required for a pseudo-cleft – the locative cannot correspond to a gap of a locative argument/adjunct contained within the remainder portion of the *wh*-question.⁶

⁶Example (14) apparently improves if the remainder is a headed relative clause, as in (i):

- (i) Nasaan ang lugar kung saan inilagay ni Juan ang matrilyo?
 PRED.LOC UNM place C[+Q] where put DEP Juan UNM hammer
 ‘Where is the place where Juan put the hammer?’

Speakers report when asked that (i) involves a familiarity and uniqueness requirement. For instance, (i) makes most sense in the context of a comprehension question asked of a child who has been told a story involving

The argument made here may be summarized as follows: If there is a contrast between DPs and non-DPs with respect to forming interrogatives (the former utilizing a pseudo-cleft, the latter involving *wh*-movement), we ought to see this contrast neutralized for locatives which have a distinct form reflecting their use as an argument/adjunct or as a predicate. That is, one might reason that *wh*-phrases such as *kailan* (‘when’), or *bakit* (‘why’) – as opposed, e.g., to *sino/ano* (‘who/what’) – must undergo *wh*-movement because they cannot, for whatever reason, function as predicates. But such an explanation would fail when it comes to the locative, which can function either as an argument/adjunct or as a predicate and – in its predicate form – should, all other things being equal, be able to function as the predicate of a pseudo-clefted *wh*-question. If these conclusions are correct, then it follows that *wh*-movement is the unmarked mechanism for forming *wh*-questions in at least certain contexts even when a pseudo-cleft analysis is otherwise also available. In other words, while the argument here does not allow us to completely rule out a pseudo-cleft analysis for some *wh*-questions, it does make it plain that it is not the only available (or even preferred) strategy for constructing questions even when the conditions for using it would be met.

3.2 Possessor Inversion

This section offers an argument for a *wh*-movement analysis of interrogatives in Tagalog based on obligatory inversion of *wh*-phrases that are possessors within possessed DPs. In many languages with both (obligatory) *wh*-fronting and canonically post-nominal possessors, a possessor must appear pre-nominally in *wh*-questions. This phenomenon is particularly well-documented for many Mesoamerican languages (Aissen 1996, Broadwell 2001, Coon 2009), but is also attested in other language families and languages including Austronesian (e.g., Marshalese, as described in Wilson-Sturman 2014); French (e.g., *dont*-relatives, as described in Kayne 1975 and Heck 2009); and Polish (Rappaport 1995).⁷ The pattern of inversion of possessor *wh*-phrases is documented for Tzotzil by Aissen (1996), and is nearly perfectly replicated in Tagalog.

First, like Tzotzil, non-pronominal possessors in Tagalog canonically appear post-nominally.

(16) *Tagalog*:

- a. Ang mga laruan ng bata
UNM PL toy DEP child
‘children’s toys’
(English, 481, entry for *entresuwelo*)
- b. *ang bata(-ng) mga laran
UNM child(-LK) PL toy
(‘children’s toys’)

Juan. As a question with possible alternative answers however, it seems inappropriate. Speakers also seemed inclined to judge this sentence as acceptable as a “echo” questions. See Section 4.4.1 for further details relating to the semantics of *wh*-questions.

⁷Pied-piping with inversion also occurs in some languages in which a *wh*-phrase inverts with the preposition it is a complement of. See the discussion of Royer et. al. 2026 in the main text for some discussion.

(17) *Tzotzil*:

- a. s-p'in li Maruch-e
A3-pot the Maruch-ENC
‘Maruch’s pot’
- b. *Maruch s-p'in
Maruch A3-pot

In Tzotzil, if the possessor is a *wh*-phrase it must invert with the possessed noun and the entire possessive DP is pied-piped by *wh*-movement.

(18) *Tzotzil*:

- a. [Buch'u x-ch'amal]₁ i-cham ____₁?
who A3-child CP-died
‘Whose child died?’
- b. *[X-ch'amal buch'u]₁ i-cham ____₁?
A3-child who CP-died
(Whose child died?)

The same process of inversion appears to occur in Tagalog as well. In the examples in (19) below, for example, when the possessor is a *wh*-phrase, it must occur initially (pre-nominally) within the larger DP.

- (19) a. [_{DP} [_{DP} **Kaninong** **aso**]₁ ang kumagat *t*₁ sa iyo?
who(OBL).LK child UNM AV.PERF.bit OBL 1SG(OBL)
‘Whose dog bit you?’
- b. [_{DP} **Kaninong** **aklat**]₁ ang pipili-in mo *t*₁?
who.(OBL).LK book UNM PERF.choose-PV 2SG(DEP)?
‘Whose book will you choose?’
- c. [_{DP} **Kaninong** **malakas na boses**]₁ ang na-rinig ni Manoka *t*₁
who.(OBL).LK loud LK voice UNM PV.PERF-head DEP Manoka
habang siya'y papalapit kumunoy?
when.LK 3SG(UNM) approach swamp
‘Whose loud voice did Manoka hear when she approaching the swamp?’
(<https://www.scribd.com/document/706702109/Filipino-6>)

Inversion of the *wh*-phrase with the head noun denoting the possessee is thus similar if not identical to the process referred to as *genitive inversion* by Hsieh (2023), in which a pronominal possessor may optionally invert with a head noun, as illustrated by the examples in (20).

- (20) a. ang aking bata
UNM 1SG(OBL).LK child
‘my child’

- b. ang bata ko
UNM chid 1SG(DEP)
'my child'

According to Hsieh's description, this process is entirely optional for standard pronouns. By contrast, when the possessor is a *wh*-phrase, genitive inversion appears to be obligatory. Thus, while the examples in (20) are equally grammatical, examples like (21) (cf. the example in (19)) are not.⁸

- (21) a. *_{[DP (Ang) aso (ng) **nino**]₁} ang kumagat _{t₁ sa iyo?}
UNM dog DEP who.DEP UNM NOM.PERF.bit OBL 2SG(OBL)
(‘The/a dog of whom bit you?’)
b. *_{[DP (Ang) aklat (ng) **nino**]₁} ang pipili-in mo _{t₁?}
UNM book DEP who.DEP S choose 2SG(DEP)
(‘The/a book of whom did you choose?’)

In many contemporary accounts of this phenomenon in other languages where it has been observed, the inversion of the *wh*-phrase is taken to be tied to *wh*-movement. Concretely, when the possessor is a *wh*-phrase that is questioned, it cannot move alone but can

⁸An anonymous reviewer provides examples (i) as an example where there is inversion of the *wh*-phrase possessor but the larger phrase containing it remains in-situ. The example involves a multiple question, of the sort that allows *wh*-in-situ in English as well.

- (i) Sino ang nag-nakaw ng kaninong pera?
who AV.PERF.-stole DEP who(OBL).LK money
'Who stole whose money?'

If this example is indeed grammatical, it would appear to be an exception to my more general claim. However, the review also provides example (ii), without inversion, and states that it is grammatical.

- (ii) Sino ang nag-nakaw ng pera nino?
who AV.PERF-steal DEP money who(DEP)
'Who stole who's money?'

If both (i) and (ii) are grammatical, this does not necessarily pose a problem for the claim in the main text, which is that inversion is obligatory if there is concomitant *wh*-movement. Inversion could happen optionally otherwise (i.e., if there is no *wh*-movement, as with pronouns in general). It should be noted here also, that if the review is correct that examples like (i)-(ii) are grammatical, these examples themselves would pose a problem for a pseudo-cleft analysis, as such an analysis would not generally predict multiple *wh*-questions to be possible. More generally, multiple *wh*-questions involve a situation where more than one *wh*-phrase is associated with a *single* complementizer (see, e.g., Pesetsky 1987, 2000; Lasnik & Saito 1992; Dayal 2016 Ch.4; among others). Under a pseudo-cleft analysis, examples like the reviewer's (i)-(ii) should not exist as example of true multiple *wh*-questions since either (i) each *wh*-phrase is associated with its own complementizer; or (ii) the *wh*-phrase contained in the presumed free relative clause subject would be separated by an island from the complementizer that is associated with the main clause *wh*-phrase. At the very least, from the latter perspective example (ii) ought to be outright ungrammatical, or have an interpretation that is distinct from that of an 'ordinary' multiple question. The status of such constructions will be set aside here for future research.

only move along with the larger containing DP (which includes the posses-see) by pied-piping. For the *wh*-phrase corresponding to the possessor to pied-pipe the larger DP containing the possessor, inversion of the possessor and the head noun corresponding to the posses-see is first required (see, e.g., Aissen 1996, Cable 2010a,b, Heck 2009, and Richards 2020). Heck (2009:89), for instance, proposes the following condition to account for this obligatory inversion.

(22) *Edge Condition:*

If α pied-pipes β , then α must be at the edge of β .

Because the *Edge Condition* is a condition on pied-piping, it presupposes that the *wh*-phrase and the phrase containing the *wh*-phrase (by pied-piping) have undergone movement – i.e., that a language for which this condition holds is a language with *wh*-movement and not a *wh*-in-situ language. This, in fact, seems to also be built into analyses such as Aissen (1996) and Heck (2009). It also features in the analysis of Cable (2010a, b), though the link between inversion of a *wh*-phrase with a noun is somewhat more indirect. In particular, Cable (2010a, b) proposes that pied-piping is an epiphenomenon, relating to the movement of a QP constituent which happens to host a *wh*-phrase. What is traditionally called *wh*-movement, then, is actually movement of a QP to C. In principle, this movement is independent of the location of a *wh*-phrase within QP, such that either of the two derivations/structures in (23) could in principle be grammatical. Languages that do not allow the derivation in (23b) Cable refers to as *limited pied-piping* languages.

- (23) a. [CP [QP Q *WhP* ... X] [C' C ...
 b. [CP [QP Q X ... *WhP*] [C' C ...

Cable defines limited pied-piping as in (24), which would characterize languages like Tzotzil and Tagalog.

- (24) A *limited pied-piping structure* is a pied-piping structure where pied-piping past an adjunct island and pied-piping past lexical categories is not permitted.

In order for a *wh*-phrase in structure like (23b) to pied-pipe, Cable contends, there must be Agreement between Q and the *wh*-phrase and concomitant movement of the *wh*-phrase to QP's edge, yielding the structure in (23a) with inversion of the *wh*-phrase and its possessum. Crucially, inversion yielding a structure like (23a) would be found only if there is pied-piping and hence only if *wh*-movement occurs.⁹

Though *wh*-movement within QP is (theoretically) independent of movement of QP to Spec, CP for Cable (2010), Richards (2020), who also observes the link between inversion and *wh*-movement, suggests that the two operations are intimately connected. Richards' account is based on Contiguity Theory (Richards 2016, Ch. 3; Richards 2010 Ch. 3) and the principle of *Generalized Contiguity* stated in (25).

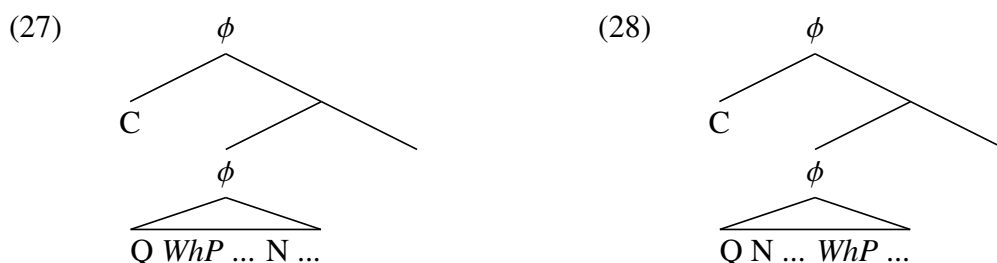
⁹More specifically, this holds for a language where the expected word order is head initial, and X would be expected to occur before the *wh*-phrase.

- (25) If α either Agrees with or selects β , α and β must be dominated by a single prosodic node, within which β is Contiguity-prominent.

Contiguity-prominent is defined as in (26).¹⁰

- (26) Given a ϕ (phonological phrase), F, contained in another ϕ , G, F is Contiguity-prominent in G if F is not linearly separated from a prosodically active edge of G by another ϕ .

In Richards (2010), Richards argues that Tagalog phonological phrases are prosodically active on their left-edge. Given that Tagalog is also C-initial, this entails that *wh*-phrases in the language will surface as far to the left-periphery of the clause as possible. To illustrate, the partial syntactic/prosodic structure in (27) is one that respects *Contiguity Prominence* between C and the *wh*-phrase, whereas the one in (28) does not. The structure in (27) represents one where a *wh*-phrase is contiguity prominent within QP, and where QP (and hence, the *wh*-phrase) is contained in a larger phrase that is contiguity prominent with C. In the structure in (28), on the other hand, there is intervening material (namely, a prosodic word corresponding to N) between Q and the *wh*-phrase within QP (violating contiguity prominence within QP), and hence between C and the *wh*-phrase in the larger structure as well. This could represent, for instance, a phrase containing a *wh*-phrase introduced post-nominally (i.e., no inversion of the possessor).



Now, in and of itself, Contiguity Prominence does not entail that Tagalog forms its *wh*-questions by movement since an initial *wh*-phrase functioning as the predicate would also be Contiguity-prominent (assuming inversion in the case of *wh*-phrase possessors). That said, Richards (2020) does aim to relate the parallel nature of *wh*-movement with that of *wh*-inversion within a larger DP (i.e., pied-piping with inversion). He observes, for instance, that in languages with *wh*-movement, C and QP (=the host of a *wh*-phrase, according to Cable's proposal which is adopted by Richards) must respect contiguity. In these languages, for the most part, Q and a *wh*-phrase must also respect contiguity. Hence, if QP must move so as to align with C, so too a *wh*-phrase dominated by QP must move to align with Q for Contiguity. If a language is head-initial (more specifically, if C and Q are head initial) and have a prominent left-edge, then a *wh*-phrase must move to the left edge of QP, and QP to

¹⁰Richards assumes a version of *Match Theory* proposed in Selkirk (2011) for the mapping between syntax and phonological form.

the left edge of CP as in Tzotzil and the other languages cited above. By contrast, a language that is *wh*-in-situ might be one in which C is initial but the language is prosodically active at the right edge rather than the left. Given Richards' procedure for *Grouping* (Richards 2010:82-85), this allows a ϕ to be created above C and will thus allow for the *wh*-phrase to be contiguous prominent within the ϕ containing both C and the *wh*-phrase without requiring *wh*-movement of the *wh*-phrase. French, which allows optional *wh*-movement, would be a language of this type, for example. Zulu (Sabel and Zeller 2006; cited in Richards 2020:564) is another such language.

- (29) *Zulu*:
- a. U-bonna-ni?
2sg-see-what
'What do you see?'
 - b. Ngi-buze [ukuthi uPeter u-thenge-ni]?
1sg-ask that 1a.Peter 1a-bought-what.9
'I asked what Peter bought.'
(Sabel & Zeller 2006:271, 272)

In complex noun phrases containing a *wh*-phrase as possessor, inversion with the posses-sum is not required (or possibly even allowed), as demonstrated by example (30) (Richards 2020:565, citing a personal communication with Claire Halpert).

- (30) [Isibonelo sika-bani] oku-melwe si-si-landel-e?
AUG.7.example 7.ASSOC.1-1.who 17.REL-ought 1PL.S7.O-follow-SUBJ
'The example of who ought we to follow.'

Another illustration of this comes from a language, Anejom̃ (Austronesian, Vanuatu; Lynch 2000). In Anejom̃, possessors occur post-nominally.¹¹

- (31) *Anejom̃*:
- a. nijma-k
hand-my

¹¹This is potentially one example language among many that were discovered by a simple search on WALS (*Word Atlas of Language Structures* (Dryer & Haspelmath 2013)) using the parameters for possessor order ('86A:Order of Genitive and N') in concordance with the parameter for *wh*-initial or *wh*-non-initial ('93A:Position of Interrogative Phrases'). I selected the language here because it had the most accessible grammatical sketch with examples. A look through other languages that might have a similar profile would require a more thorough study. The languages of interest from the data-base would be those described as not having a dominant order for N and genitive (=possessor) – specifically, does the flexibility become fixed to Gen > N word order in languages that also have *wh*-movement? The WALS data base has 26 languages that match these parameters, but an initial attempt to look into these is limited by the fact that (i) to the grammars of the languages is limited or minimal, and/or (ii) does not include information about extraction of possessed DP's in its section on forming questions, which is limited to rather simplex *wh*-words. Hopefully, more time and greater documentation of the languages will assist in testing the hypotheses put forward here.

- ‘my hand’
 b. nida-i n̄ɔded
 name-cs bush.spirit
 the bush spirit’s name’
 (Lynch 2000:page)

The language is also *wh*-in-situ, as Lynch’s description and the examples like those in (32) are intended to illustrate (the language is VOXS).

- (32) a. Et awod **di** aan?
 3SG.AR hit who (s)he
 ‘Who did she hit?’
 b. Et pu apam plen **a nuhuḗan**?
 3SG.AR FUT come plane LOC when
 ‘When will the plane come?’

And as the examples in (33) below illustrate, when the *wh*-phrases corresponds to a possessor in a larger DP, it appears after the possessum (post-nominally) – i.e., the same as the order in examples like (31) above .

- (33) a. Et awod [kuri **u di**] aan?
 3SG.AR hit dog POSS.G who (s)he
 ‘Whose dog did she hit?’
 b. Et attii [incai **u di**] aen?
 3SG.AR cut-down tree POSS.G who (s)he
 ‘Whose tree did she cut down?’
 (Lynch 174-167)

It is reasonable at this point to ask how the Tagalog facts might be analyzed under a pseudo-cleft analysis of interrogatives. As a first possibility, we might consider an approach put forward by Royer et. al. (2026). In their work, Royer et. al. put forward a pseudo-cleft analysis for *wh*-questions on Chuj (Mayan). Although Chuj is not claimed by Royer et. al. to have obligatory inversion of *wh*-phrase possessors, it does apparently have obligatory inversion of *wh*-phrase complements of prepositions. Royer et. al. analyze this obligatory inversion in such a way that inversion is not actually involved. Concretely, they claim that the *wh*-phrase in an example like (34) is a predicate, and the remainder is a headless relative clause whose gap is created by movement of a null operator. Movement of the null operator forming a gap inside the relative clause pied-pipes the preposition along with it, yielding the structure shown in (35), in which the overt *wh*-phrase precedes the preposition giving rise to apparent inversion of these elements.

- (34) Mach yet' ol-ach-b'at-ok *t*?
 who with PROSP-B2S-go-IRR
 'With whom will you go'/Lit. 'Who with will you go?'
 (Royer et. al. 2026:20)

- (35) [_{PredP} Mach] [_{DP} NP [_{CP} [_{PP} yet' *Op*] ol-ach-b'at-ok *t*]]

The problem with this analysis is one of independent motivation. It is well known that null operators in general do not make for very good pied-pipers in contrast to overt *wh*-phrases. Descriptively, at least, this observation provides a basis for talking about the contrast seen in the examples (36), with (36b) illustrating that a null operator cannot pied-pipe a preposition in English.

- (36) a. Sam is the person [_{CP} *Op* to talk with *t* about that].
 b. *Sam is the person [_{CP} [with *Op*] to talk *t* about that].

Applying the same idea for preposition inversion as Royer et. al. to possessor inversion in Tagalog would involve deriving an example like (19a) above repeated below as (37) as depicted in (38). In (38), the oblique *wh*-phrase *kanino* ('whose(OBL)') would be the predicate of the pseudo-cleft. Within the free relative clause subject, a null operator functions as the possessor of a DP, and movement of this null operator would involve pied-piping the rest of the content of the DP containing it, which includes the head that expresses the possessum (i.e., *aso Op*).¹²

- (37) [**Kaninong aso**]₁ ang kumagat *t*₁ sa iyo?
 who(OBL).LK dog bit OBL you
 'Whose dog bit you?'

- (38) [_{PredP} **kaninong**] [_{DP} NP [_{CP} [_{DP} [_{NP} **aso Op**]] [kumagat *t* sa iyo]]

The derivation sketched in (38) is dubious for a few reasons: First, as already noted, null operators do not make particularly good pied-pipers. Second, the analysis leaves unaccounted for the oblique form of the *wh*-phrase which is putatively functioning as the predicate in the pseudo-cleft structure. As noted above with respect to standard pronominal possessors as in the examples in (20), the presence of oblique case on a pronominal possessor occurs when the possessor occurs pre-nominally rather than post-nominally, in which case they appear in the genitive (or *DEP*) case form. Although I am unable to provide a full analysis of the alternation here, it should be plain enough that the change in case form from *DEP* to *OBL* case is connected to inversion of the possessor and posses-see within DP as discussed in greater detail in Hsieh (2025:537). The fact that the *wh*-phrase possessor

¹²A similar-style analysis is proposed for Marshalese in Wilson-Sturman (2014). There, the author proposes that the possessor *wh*-phrase is the predicate, and the posses-see is the overt head of a relative clause subject. This analysis would not extent to Tagalog for the reasons cited in the main text, as well as because this analysis would be treating the particle *ang* as a subject marker that should therefore appear between the *wh*-phrase and the posses-see (=head of the relative clause subject).

obligatorily surfaces in the oblique case in questions like (19) therefore strongly suggests that it and the posses-see constitute a constituent within which inversion has applied. An analysis like (38), which treats the inversion as only apparent, has no obvious means to connect the oblique surface form of the *wh*-phrase with the paradigm in (20), which shows the case alternation to be a general fact about inversion of (pronominal) possessors within the DP.

Finally, the analysis in (38) incorrectly splits the possessor and its posses-see into distinct constituents. The presence of the ‘linker’ element that surfaces at the end of the oblique *wh*-phrase in the examples above, however, is as plain a sign as any that the *wh*-phrase must be directly connected to something in adposition to it. In other words, the linker element quite generally surfaces in context where a phrase modifies another phrase, such as when an NP is modified by an AP (e.g., *bago=ng damit* ‘new dress’). The presence of the linker element is unaccounted for given the structure in (38), since there, the *wh*-phrase does not directly modify anything in this structure but rather is a completely independent phrase. Semantically, of course, it modifies *aso* (‘dog’), but this is not transparent from the syntax. If nothing more, it is a function of the ‘linker’ to make modification transparent in the surface syntax.¹³ The upshot of this is that the phrases like *kaninong aso* are constituents in the syntax, contra what the analysis in (38) contends.

A second possibility to consider is that the pseudo-cleft predicate (=the *wh*-phrase in interrogatives) actually undergoes movement from the underlying pseudo-cleft structure. This, in fact, is what Potsdam (2007:581-582) claims occurs in Malagasy. In particular, because Malagasy derives its verb initial word order by a process of “VP raising”, in which the entire predicate phrase (the vP, or a projection containing the vP) is fronted to a position before the subject, *wh*-phrases, which function as the predicate phrase in interrogatives according to the pseudo-cleft analysis, must also undergo “VP raising”. If this is correct for Tagalog as well, then the pied-piping facts would follow for Tagalog as they do for a language that derives interrogatives by *wh*-movement. This analysis is untenable. In Section 4.2, I offer an argument that Tagalog does not derive its verb initial word order by the process of “VP raising”, and that such a process is unlikely available more generally. If these arguments are sound, then it follows that a *wh*-phrase predicate in a pseudo-cleft structure must be in-situ, and obligatory inversion should not be observed, as inversion seems to be linked to a *wh*-phrase’s ability to pied-pipe. Since pied-piping entails movement, it therefore follows that movement is involved in the derivation of *wh*-questions like (19) in Tagalog.

3.3 Modal and Particle Placement

In his work on the structure of interrogatives in Malagasy, Potsdam (2006, 2007)¹⁴ devotes much attention to arguing that interrogative questions in Malagasy have a bi-clausal structure (specifically, that they have a pseudo-cleft structure). To make the case, Potsdam

¹³In fact, Rubin (1994) and Scontras & Nocolae (2014) provide an explicit semantics for the linker that develops from this intuition.

¹⁴See Potsdam (2009) on Fijian. See also Potsdam & Polinsky (2011).

focusses on the distribution of elements that he takes to be associated with the functional head, I(nfl) (represented as T(ense), in the trees below).¹⁵ These include the Malagasy elements *tokony* ('should'), an emphatic element *tena* ('indeed'), as well as the future-marking element *ho*. For lack of a more precise term, I will refer to these as T(ENSE)A(SPECT)M(MOOD)-words. These elements precede the verb in standard VOS clauses (as in (39a)), and also precede *wh*-phrases in *wh*-questions (as in (39b)).

- (39) a. **Tokony** hamangy an-dRabe Rasoa.
 should visit.ACT ACC-Rabe Rasoa
 'Rasoa should visit Rabe.'
 b. **Tokony** iza₁ no hamangy an-dRabe *t*₁?
 should who PRT visit.ACT ACC-Rabe
 'Who should visit Rabe?'
 (Potsdam 2006, 2165-2166)

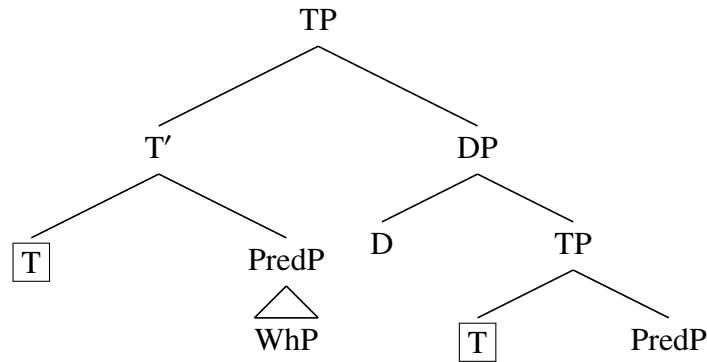
In *wh*-questions, as Potsdam notes, it is also possible for a TAM-word to appear after the particle *no* and after the *wh*-phrase, but before the remainder of the clause which contains the main verb containing a gap associated with the *wh*-phrase. This word order is illustrated in example (40).

- (40) Iza₁ no **tokony** hamangy an-dRabe *t*₁?
 who PRT should visit.ACT ACC-Rabe
 'Who should visit Rabe?'
 (Potsdam 2006, 2167; compare with 36b)

For Potsdam, the equivalent grammaticality of the forms in (39b) and (40) follows from two main assertions: First, and foremost, *wh*-question in Malagasy have a pseudo-cleft structure (sketched schematically below as (41)). Second, TAM-words like *tokony* are a morphological realization of the head IP/TP (=I/T). Given these two assumptions, there are two logical positions for words like *tokony* in the above examples to occur in based on the biclausal structure associated with a pseudo-cleft analysis. These are the boxed positions in the structure in (41).

¹⁵For Potsdam's argument, and for the argument I will make for Tagalog, the identification of these elements as Infl/Tense is not crucial. Instead, it is only important that these elements are generally merged to the (immediate) left of a predicate or predicate phrase. In fact, Paul & Potsdam (2008), and Potsdam (2007) seem to take this later, more neutral view.

(41)



Crucially, comparison of the facts in Malagasy with those in Tagalog would appear to point to a very different conclusion. Sabbagh (2013 :46-49) (see also Kroeger 1993:Chapter 6) observes that Tagalog also has a set of elements that must, in general, precede a verb in simple sentences. These include the elements *dapat* ('must'), *baka* ('might'), and *maaari* ('can') (the latter specifically seems to be roughly equivalent to *tokony* in Malagasy). Relevantly for our purposes, these elements seem to function as their counterparts in Malagasy as modals (i.e., TAM-words) and therefore might reasonably be assigned to the category T in Tagalog as well. Consider the following examples.

- (42) a. **Dapat** tupar-in ni Mark ang pangako niya sa taong iyon
 must INF.KEEP-PV GEN Mark UNM promise 3SG(DEP) OBL person.LK that
 'Mark must keep his promise to that person.'
- b. **Dapat ko-ng** tupar-in ang aking pangako sa taong iyon.
 must 1SG(DEP)-LK INF.KEEP-PV UNM 1SG(DEP).LK promise OBL person.LK
 that
 'I must keep my promise to that person.'
- (43) a. **Baka** bumili si Juan ng bagong suit.
 might AV.INF.buy UNM Juan DEP new.LK suit
 'Juan might buy a new suit.'
- b. **Baka ko-ng** bayar-an ang aking respeto sa kanya ...
 might 1SG(DEP)-LK INF.pay-PV UNM my respect OBL him
 'I might pay my respects to him...'
(Paggising Sa Buddhahood: Awakening into Buddhahood in Filipino, by Nam H Nguyen)

In declarative sentences, these TAM-words must appear before the verb. The reverse order is ungrammatical, as the examples in (44) demonstrate.

- (44) a. *Tupar-in **dapat** ni Mark ang pangako niya sa taong iyon
 INF.KEEP-PV must DEP Mark UNM promise 3SG(DEP) OBL person.LK that
 'Mark must keep his promise to that person.'

- b. **Bumili baka* si Juan ng bagong suit.
 AV.INF.buy might UNM Juan DEP new.LK suit
 ‘Juan might buy a new suit.’

Keeping the last point in mind, note that in Tagalog *wh*-questions, the *wh*-phrase must occur (directly) before the pre-verbal TAM-words. Consider the examples in (45), where we observe the grammatical order: WH > PARTICLE > TAM > v in (45a), which contrasts with the ungrammatical order TAM > WH > PART > v in (45b).

- (45) a. **Sino** ang [**dapat** mag-bayad sa date]?
 who should AV.INF-pay OBL date
 ‘Who should pay for the date?’ (web)
 b. ***Dapat sino** ang [mag-bayad sa date]?
 should who AV.INF-pay OBL date

As an additional example, consider the examples in (46), involving the TAM-word *maaari* (‘can’). The distribution of *maaari* appears to be identical to *dapat* and *baka* – it must occur after the *wh*-phrase but before the main verb: ¹⁶

- (46) a. **Sino-sino** ang [**maaring** maging sapatero]?
 who-who can.LK INF.become shoemaker
 ‘Who can become a shoemaker?’
 b. ***Maaaring sino-sino** ang [m-aging sapatero]?
 can.LK who-who INF.become shoemaker
 (‘Who can become a shoemaker?’)

These facts, in particular the (b) examples of (45)-(46), contrast with the facts documented for Malagasy by Potsdam. Concretely, the difference between Malagasy and Tagalog may be compared and summarized as follows (PART corresponds to *ang* in Tagalog, *no* in Malagasy).

- | | |
|------------------------|-----------------------|
| (47) <i>Malagasy</i> : | (48) <i>Tagalog</i> : |
| a. WH > PART > TAM | a. WH > PART > TAM |
| b. TAM > WH > PART | b. *TAM > WH > PART |

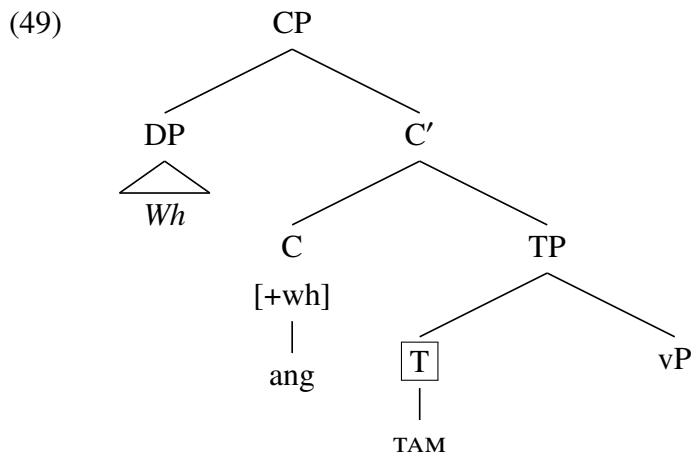
Crucially, if we apply Potsdam’s reasoning about Malagasy to Tagalog, the absence of examples with the word order in (45b, 46b) leads us to conclude that *wh*-questions in Tagalog are mono-clausal. Under a mono-clausal analysis, there can be only one T position

¹⁶As far as I have been able to tell, sentences with the order TAM > PART are ungrammatical:

- (i) *Sino dapat ang mag-bayad sa date?
 who should AV.INF.pay OBL date
 ‘Who should pay for the date?’

In theory, this word order could be derived from a pseudo-cleft base structure by movement of the predicate *wh*-phrase to Spec, CP. As I argue in Section 4, such a mechanism is unlikely to be available to the language.

in the clause, and this T position crucially follows the *wh*-phrase and the remainder of the question. This is illustrated by the tree in (49). (Note, I have analyzed the particle *ang* as C[+wh] in (49), an analysis that I will attempt to justify in Section 4.5.)



The ungrammatical word order TAM > *Wh* in the above examples can be explained given this structure because there is only one T position to host a TAM-word, and it occurs to the right of the *wh*-phrase but to the left of the main verb. This result follows if (i) interrogative questions are mono-clausal; and (ii) *wh*-phrases in Tagalog undergo *wh*-movement. If the reasoning here is sound, then we have another confirmation for the main thesis of this paper: *wh*-questions in Tagalog (in particular, those based on arguments) do not necessarily always involve a pseudo-cleft structure.¹⁷

3.4 Connectivity

Adger & Ramchand (2005) argue that *wh*-questions in Gaelic, as in (50), take the form of a pseudo-cleft as schematized in (51).

- (50) Dè a' chraobh a bha thu a'geàrradh?
 which the children C-REL be-PAST you cutting
 'Which tree were you cutting?'
 (Adger & Ramchand 2005: pp. 169, exx. (32))

¹⁷As with previous arguments, the argument here does not rule out the pseudo-cleft entirely. What it minimally shows is that in a certain context – e.g., in the presence of TAM-words – the pseudo-cleft strategy is unavailable (thus accounting for the ungrammaticality of (48b)). Why should the pseudo-cleft strategy be unavailable in the presence of TAM-words? At this point, I would speculate that it is because the TAM-words in Tagalog cannot be semantically composed directly with a *wh*-phrase as predicate, or – perhaps – doing so produces a different meaning because the TAM-word has scope over different things depending on its location. Whatever the merits of such speculation, the difficult question that remains is why Tagalog and Malagasy would differ – why, in Malagasy – can TAM-words directly take the predicative *wh*-phrase as their complement? I leave this question open for further contemplation.

- (51) Copula [*wh*-phrase] [relative clause]
 Ø Dé a' charoabh C-REL be-PAST you cutting

While it is not my intention here to refute their analysis for Gaelic, I scrutinize some of their arguments to determine the extent to which they might extend to Tagalog. I conclude that they do not. The facts to be discussed involve “connectivity effects” (their presence, and lack thereof) in *wh*-questions. The topic of connectivity with respect to pseudo-cleft structure in general has been a matter of long-standing discussion (see, e.g., Higgins 1973; Williams 1983, 1994; Iatridou & Varlakosta 1998, Heycock & Korch 1999; Sharvit 1999; Cecchetto 2000; Heller 2002; among others). The discussion below is limited in scope, and will focus mainly on showing that certain connectivity effects fail to arise in predictable ways for Tagalog, while other connectivity effects do predictably arise in ways that are supportive of a mono-clausal syntax for *wh*-questions based on a derivation involving *wh*-movement.

3.4.1 Non-Identity Effects

One of Adger & Ramchand’s arguments for a pseudo-cleft-analysis of *wh*-questions in Gaelic is based on the contrast between (52) and (53).

- (52) Dè a' chraobh a bha thu a'geàrradh
 which the tree-NOM C-REL be-PAST you cutting
 ‘Which tree were you cutting?’
- (53) *Dè na craobhe a bha thu a'geàrradh
 which the tree-GEN C-REL be-PAST you cutting
 (‘Which tree were you cutting?’)
 (Adger & Ramchand 2005: pp.169, exx. (31), (31))

The ungrammaticality of (53), according to A&R is problematic from the perspective of standard *wh*-movement, because the object of the verb *a'gearradh* (‘cut’) in these examples should be associated with a lexical-case of the genitive form, but *wh*-phrase must surface in the nominative rather than the genitive case. This fact, according to A&R, represent an instance of *Case Mismatch*, and militates against an analysis for *wh*-questions in Gaelic in which the *wh*-phrase is connected to a trace of the object position of the verb *a'gearradh* (or any position consisting of a gap following the *wh*-phrase). Case mismatch is unproblematic for a pseudo-cleft analysis because the *wh*-phrase and the gap are not directly connected (i.e., via movement), and there is therefore no expectation that the *wh*-phrase must match the case that would be assigned in the position of the gap contained within the remainder of the clause (i.e., within the free relative clause).

At first blush, it would seem that a similar argument might be made for Tagalog. First, the internal argument of a typical transitive verb in Tagalog is assigned DEP case in the ‘Actor-voice’. Certain verbs, however, seem to require their internal argument to be expressed in the oblique case. Consider the examples in (54)-(55). The object of the transitive verb *basa* (‘read’) in (54) is assigned DEP-case, as is typical for objects of transitive verbs. Objects of

verbs such as *hilig* ('love') and *gusto* ('want/like'), however, are assigned an idiosyncratic oblique case, as shown in (55).

- (54) Nag-babasa ako ng libro.
 AV-IMPERF-read 1SG(UNM) DEP book.
 'I read the book.'
- (55) a. Na-hilig ako sa mga maikling kwento.
 AV.PERF-love 1SG(UNM) OBL PL short.lk shory
 'I loved (used to love) short stories.'
 b. Gusto ko sa isang babae.
 want 1SG(DEP) OBL a.LK woman
 'I want/like a woman.'

Sa-marked nominals may also serve as locative arguments, as shown in (56), but there they will be glossed as *LOC* in order to distinguish them from the idiosyncratic oblique case-marked arguments.

- (56) Nag-lagay ako ng mga libro sa desk.
 AV.PERF-put 1SG(UNM) DEP PL book LOC desk
 'I put some books on the desk.'

As seen in (55), a verb like *gusto* ('like, want') is associated with an idiosyncratic oblique case on its object. This argument, as shown in (57) may be questioned, but the *wh*-phrase, as we saw to be the case for Gaelic, must appear in the *UNMARKED* case-form (equivalent to the nominative) rather than the idiosyncratic oblique case.¹⁸

- (57) Anong kwento=ng gustuh-an mo t?
 what.LK story=C PERF.like-PV 2SG.GEN
 'What/which story did you like?'

If the *wh*-phrase surfaces in the oblique case, the result is ungrammatical.

- (58) *Sa ano=ng/kanino=ng kwento=ng gustuh-an mo t?
 OBL what.LK/what(OBL)=LK story=C PERF.like-APPL 2SG.GEN
 ('(to) what story did you like?')

The ungrammaticality of (58) seems to parallel A&R's example (53), and therefore might be taken as evidence for a pseudo-cleft analysis of Tagalog *wh*-questions. However, there is another explanation for the contrast between (57) and (58). Concretely, and as previously noted (see Section 2), the verb in Tagalog must have some kind of affix which has the general property of indicating which argument of the verb functions syntactically as the subject of the clause (i.e., the nominative/unmarked DP). Significantly, Tagalog has a series of affixes that allow for non-core-arguments of a verb to be realized as a subject (see, e.g.,

¹⁸In these examples, I have glossed the linker element ([=η]) as a C. See the discussion in Section 3.5 for explanation.

Rackowski 2002, who analyzes these as *applicative* constructions). For instance, a benefactive (typically expressed as an adjunct), may function as the subject if the appropriate *applicative* morpheme is used. The following examples serve to illustrate.

- (59) a. Bumili ako ng bola para sa kanya.
 AV.PERF.buy 1SG(UNM) DEP ball for OBL 3SG(OBL)
 ‘I bought a ball for him.’
 b. I-bili ko siya ng bola .
 APPL_{ben}-PERF.buy 1SG(DEP) 3SG(UNM) DEP ball
 ‘I bought him a ball.’

This process of applicativization also allows for the possessor of an (internal) argument to function as the subject, as illustrated by the alternation between examples (60a-b) (see Nie 2019 and references therein for fuller discussion).

- (60) a. In-ayos niya [ang buhok ni Tina].
 PV.PERF-arrange 3SG(DEP) UNM hair DEP Maria
 ‘She arranged Tina’s hair.’
 b. In-ayos-an niya ng buhok [si Tina].
 PV.PERF-arrange-APPL_{loc} 3SG(DEP) DEP hair UNM Tina
 ‘She arranged Tina’s hair.’

Note that sentence (61), where the internal argument’s possessor is the subject but the morphology of the verb does not have the correct locative applied form. This sentence (and others like it) are completely ungrammatical.

- (61) *In-ayos niya ng buhok [si Tina].
 PV.PERF-arrange 3SG(DEP) GEN hair UNM Tina
 ‘She arranged Tina’s hair.’

Now, and crucially, $\bar{A}$ -dependencies in Tagalog require an extracted argument to correspond to a subject. In other words, if a phrase is extracted, the verb must bare the morphology that is associated with the subject-hood of that argument.¹⁹ Viewed from this perspective, the contrast between (57) and (58) can now be seen as involving an instantiation of this ‘Subject only’ restriction on extraction. Concretely, in (57) the oblique-marked object is a subject, and hence takes on the UNM-case (i.e., nominative) form. When the oblique-marked object is promoted to subject, it does not retain its oblique case, and – hence – sentence (58) is ungrammatical. There is, then, no case-mismatch of the type described by Adger & Ramchand (2004) for Gaelic, as the contrast between (57)-(58) follows from a (well-documented) Tagalog specific grammatical constraint.

¹⁹This is the ‘Subject Only’ restriction on extraction. See references given at the end of Section 2. See also Pizarro-Guerva & Wagers (2024), and Hsieh (2020, 2026) for important recent discussion.

3.4.2 Reconstruction Effects

Another topic that has not been widely discussed (if at all) in connection with the analysis of *wh*-questions whether or not *Reconstruction* effects of the type very familiar to studies on *wh*-movement and $\bar{A}$ -Movement more generally are associated with questions in Tagalog. For instance, as noted in Barss (1986) and many others in its wake, *wh*-phrases can behave as if they are unmoved for purposes of phenomenon such as reflexive binding (Principle A effects) (see also, Sportiche 2017, and references therein for a recent overview of reconstruction effects).

(62) Which photo of herself₁ does Mary₁ like *t* best?

Facts like these have been used to ‘diagnose’ movement (see, e.g., Pesetsky 2013, and the references therein). By this, one is referring to a specific analysis of *wh*-questions like (62) in which the ‘gap’ in examples is filled by something like a *copy* of its antecedent (Chomsky 1995, 2000, 2001, and references therein). Given this representation for *wh*-movement, one can say simply that Principle A is satisfied in examples like (62) because the movement chain involves identical elements (=copies), the lower of which contains a reflexive that satisfies Principle A in this location (i.e., the tail of the movement-chain). Assuming the soundness of the logic here, an important prediction is made for Tagalog: If Tagalog *wh*-questions are analyzed as pseudo-clefts, there should be no reconstruction effects. Examples like (63) show that this prediction is not born out. *Wh*-questions *do* show reconstruction effects for Principle A.

(63) Aling larawan ng *kanyang sarili*=ng₁ i-pinita ni Maria₁ *t*?
 what.LK picture DEP 3SG(DEP).LK self=LK PV-PERF.paint DEP Maria?
 ‘Which picture of him/her-self₁ did Maria₁ paint?’

Evidently, even in Gaelic where (root) *wh*-questions have been argued to have a pseudo-cleft structure, Principle-A effects are observed (see A&R:171, fn. 8, example (ii)). As A&R note, examples like (63) (i.e., the equivalent in Gaelic) would appear to pose a potential problem for the pseudo-cleft analysis that they propose for *wh*-questions. However, they also note that reflexives in Gaelic can (always) be used *logophorically*, which – if this is likewise true for Tagalog – would render an argument based on (63) potentially irrelevant. While the issue of logophoric uses of reflexives remains to be studied for Tagalog, there is evidence that logophoricity is not at play here. In particular, and as noted in Pesetsky (2013:130), the potential confound of logophoricity goes away when we consider examples like (64).

(64) Which picture of herself₁/*himself₂ did John₂’s mother₁ like *t* best?

The facts are pretty straightforward here: the reflexive *herself* cannot be bound to *John* because *John*, the possessor of the DP *John’s mother* which does not c-command the position of the gap. In other words, even if there is a copy of the moved *wh*-phrase in the gap position, that copy contains a reflexive which will violate Principle A.

- (65) Which picture of herself/*himself did John's mother like [which picture of x-self] best?

Thought judgments are delicate here, the same observation made for (65) in English can be made for Tagalog as well. In particular, sentence (66) below not only seems to be grammatical, it also only has the interpretation whereby the reflexive *kanyang sarili* ('her/him-self') corefers with the child and not Maria²⁰

- (66) Aling larawan ng *kanyang sarili*=ng i-pinita ng anak₁ ni Maria₂ t?
 what.LK picture DEP 3SG(DEP).LK self=LK paint DEP child DEP Maria
 'Which picture of him/her-self_{1/*2} did Maria₂'s child₁ paint?'

In (66), the reflexive can be bound by *anak ni Maria*, but not by *Maria*. This follows from Principle A (assuming reconstruction) of the *wh*-phrase. Crucially, and as a consequence, while example (63) might be dismissed as a possible instance of a logophoric use of the reflexive, this would not explain datum like (66) (see Richards 2013 for a lengthier discussion of Principle A and Principle C effects for reconstruction in Tagalog).

If further probing of the facts like (63) and (66) reveal a consistent pattern, they offer support for the fronting analysis in so far as they require the same relatively simple analysis that can be applied to English examples like (62) and (65).²¹

In the same spirit of the argument made for Principle A, consider examples (67).

²⁰Non-linguist speakers have the usual difficulty in judging examples of this level of complexity. Adding to this complication is the fact that there is no gender distinction for the (3rd person) pronouns, which presumably makes rendering a judgement even more difficult.

²¹Connectivity issues for Principle A occur in English pseudo-clefts, as in examples like (i):

- (i) What John is is important to himself.

Perhaps related to this point, a reviewer points out that reflexive binding in an example like (ii) does not rely on reconstruction:

- (ii) Sarili niya ang pinili ni Maria.
 self 3SG(DEP) UNM PV.PERF.CHOOSE DEP Maria
 'Maria chose herself.'/'Who Maria chose was herself.'

According to the reviewer, *sarili niya* ('(her) herself') is a predicate here (hence, the possible translation as a pseudo-cleft). As with a comparable pseudo-cleft in English, the reflexive appears to be licensed despite an apparent connectivity with the clause that contains its antecedent. The reviewer claims that examples like (ii) have been discussed elsewhere, though provides no references. As mentioned in the main text, the issue of connectivity in pseudo-clefts has given rise to numerous analyses over the decades, and to give an adequate response to examples like the reviewer's (ii) in relation to the argument of the main text lies beyond the scope of this article. The main point of my argument, however, is that even if reconstruction is not sufficient to explain connectedness in pseudo-clefts, it is sufficient to explain them if *wh*-question is these are derived by *wh*-movement. Of course, on its own the "reconstruction effect" reported for (63) and (66) would not be a strong argument. When considered alongside other arguments and the relative simplicity of an account based on well-known reconstruction effects with *A*-movement, however, they do – I believe – contribute to a consistent picture and thus to the larger argument.

- (67) Anong aklat ang binili ng bawa't lalaki *t* para kay Juan
 what.LK book C[wh] PV.PERF.buy DEP every boy for OBL Max
 'What book did every boy buy for Juan?'

From what I have been able to ascertain, sentence (67) has the same ambiguity as its English counterpart. This ambiguity is related to: (i) a single-question interpretation (May 1985: Chapter 2), according to which (i) there is a (possibly) single book (e.g., Chomsky's *Aspects*); or (ii) a distributed-question interpretation, according to which every boy read a (possibly) different book (e.g., Mark read *Pride & Prejudice*; Sally read *No Exit*; Lotus read *Tropic of Capricorn*; etc.). The two different logical forms in (68) and (69) offer a (crude) rendering of the interpretations for the *single-Q* and *distributed-Q* interpretations associated with (67), respectively.

- (68) *Single-Q Interpretation:*
 $WH(x): \text{book}(x). \forall(y): \text{boy}(y) \rightarrow y \text{ read } x.$
- (69) *Distributed-Q Interpretation:*
 $\forall(y): \text{boy}(y) \rightarrow WH(x): \text{book}(x). x \text{ read } y.$

Crucially, deriving the two interpretations involves two distinct positions within the clause – a position where the *wh*-phrase take scope over the quantifier *every boy*, and one where it is interpreted in its base-position below *what book*. A pseudo-cleft analysis of *wh*-questions like (67) could not, as far as I can tell, derive both interpretations. The interpretation in which the *wh*-phrase takes scope over the quantified noun phrase, for instance, cannot be derived since the universal quantifier would need to be associated with a position above the *wh*-phrase, which is not possible if it occurs in clause separate from the one that contains the *wh*-phrase. Moreover, the universal QP would be contained within a relative clause, an island, and should therefore be unable to move out of the relative clause. The two interpretations associated with sentence (67), then, serve as an additional argument for reconstruction in *wh*-questions, and – hence – for a (mono-clausal) *wh*-movement (i.e., fronting) analysis of them.²²

3.5 The Case Marker *ang* as a D and a C

One of the most cited arguments for associating interrogative questions in Tagalog with a pseudo-cleft structure derives from the observation that the element *ang* which appears in argument *wh*-questions after the *wh*-phrase and the remainder of the clause, such as (70), appears to be the same element that marks subject DPs in the language, as highlighted in the examples in (71).

²²A reviewer, presumably citing their own intuitions as a native speaker, notes that the distributive reading is “strained at best”. Of the 4 native speakers consulted, it is true that the majority of speakers (4) I consulted felt that the single-Q interpretation was the most natural, none of them judged the distributive reading to be impossible. Some inter-speaker variation is to be expected here, as some speakers (of any language) have different abilities when it comes to proving intuitions about scope.

- (70) Aling bata' **ang** mukhang pinaka-masaya?
 which.LK child appear most-happy
 'Which child looks the most happy?'

 (71) a. Mukhang pinaka-masaya **ang** itong mga bata'.
 seem.LK most-happy UNM these.LK PL child
 'These children seemed the most happy.'
 b. Kakagat-in ni Juan **ang** aso.
 CONT.bit-PV DEP Juan UNM dog
 'Juan will/might bite the dog.'

In fact, the absence of *ang* in *wh*-questions in which a PP argument or an adjunct is questioned (as in the examples in (72) below) has lead many scholars of the language (see, e.g., Richards 1998, Aldridge 2002, 2004) to concede that such questions are derived by *wh*-movement rather than by utilizing a pseudo-cleft structure.²³

- (72) a. Sa kanino naka-tira ang bata?
 OBL who.OBL AV.PERF-live.with UNM child
 'Who does the child live with?'
 b. Bakit siya na-kulong?
 why he PSV.PERF-commit
 'Why was he committed?'

Based on this plain orthographic similarity of *ang* in *wh*-questions and as the case-marker for subjects as in (72), it has been concluded that *ang* has the same function both in interrogatives and declaratives. Concretely, assuming that interrogatives take the form of a pseudo-cleft structure (with the remainder being part of a free relative clause subject), one can reasonably analyze *ang* uniformly a case marker for subjects (i.e., the realization of the UNM case). This analysis has been a mainstay of virtually all contemporary analyses of argument interrogatives for Tagalog. Below, however, I aim to show that it is an inadequate analysis given a very subtle morphosyntactic difference between the particle that appears in *wh*-questions and the particle that appears as a genuine case-marker for subjects.

To begin, the particle *ang* may be reduced in interrogative clauses (following the *wh*-phrase). When reduced, this particle typically takes the form [=ŋ] (*ng*, in orthography), which is encliticized to the final word of the *wh*-phrase. This is sometimes represented orthographically, as in the following examples (I use the IPA, [ŋ] to represent orthographic *ng*).

- (73) a. Sino=[ŋ] nag-sabi=ng bawal mahal-in ang katulad mo?
 who= AV.PERF-say=C cannot INF.love-PV UNM like you

²³ A second argument for this conclusion is based on the distribution of second position clitics. In brief, the verb in DP argument questions functions as the host for second position clitics, whereas it is the *wh*-phrase that serves as their host in PP argument and adjunct questions. Primarily for reasons of space, but also because of subcategories of second position clitics, I do not address this argument in this paper.

- ‘Who said someone like you can’t be loved’
 (<https://www.dream.com/story/2424643328-his-wolf-life-?>)
- b. Ano=[ŋ] binili mo sa sarili mo?
 what= PV.PERF.buy 2SG(DEP) OBL self 2SG(DEP)?
 ‘What did you buy for yourself?’
 (<https://www.facebook.com/watch/?v3812995818968067>)
- c. Sino=[ŋ] pumatay kay Lapu Lapu?
 who= AV.PERF.kill OBL Lapu Lapu
 ‘Who killed Lapu Lapu?’
 (https://www.youtube.com/shorts/mb1s0Z4S_2I)

In rapid speech, this enclitic may also show place assimilation with the initial consonant of the following word as in the following examples based on the transcription of Bowen (1967).²⁴

- (74) Anong (= [anum]) penitensya?
 what= penitensya
 ‘What are flagellants?’
 (Bowen 412)

The particle serving as a marker for the subject, on the other hand, is typically expressed as a proclitic to first element of the noun phrase (NP/DP) that it marks as subject. As such, the final nasal /ŋ/ of this proclitic is realized with assimilation of the final nasal of the particle to the place of the following consonant. This process is illustrated in (75), with examples from Bowen’s text (where the assimilation is phonetically transcribed) are given in (76) and (77).

- (75) a. *ang lalake* ⇒ /aŋ=lalake/ ⇒ [an=lalake]
 b. *ang pera* ⇒ /aŋ=pera/ ⇒ [am=pera]
 c. *ng isda* ⇒ /naŋ=isda/ ⇒ [naŋ=isda]
 d. *ng lalake* ⇒ /naŋ=lalake/ ⇒ [nan=lalake]
- (76) Diyan lahat *ang* ([an]=) tungo natin.
 there all UNM going 3PL(DEP)
 ‘We’re all going to the our place.’
 (Bowen 1965: 371)
- (77) Tamang-tama sa Linggo *ang* ([am]=) patapos.
 right.LK-right OBL Sunday NOM end
 ‘The end (of the novena) falls on Sunday.’
 (Bowen 1965:372)

It does, however, appear to be possible (and perhaps common in fast speech) for *ang* to appear as an enclitic with assimilation, as in the following examples. In this respect, the

²⁴Thanks to an anonymous reviewer for pointing this out.

particle appears to have the same morphological profile in *wh*-questions and non-questions.

- (78) a. Binibili mo:=m putubumbong.
 buy 2SG(DEP)=UMN puto-bumbong
 ‘(I suppose) you are buying the puto-bumbong.’
 (Bowen 1965:229)
- b. Pero mas gusto ko:=m bibingka ’t butse.
 but more like 2SG(DEP)=UNM rice-cake and butse
 ‘I prefer the bibingka and butse.’
 (Bowen 1995:229)

As a primarily descriptive matter, I take these cases (as well as cases like (74)) to involve two processes: Initial vowel deletion (of /a/ from /ang/) and nasal place assimilation. The result of these two processes is an enclitic showing nasal assimilation with the initial segment of the following word.

There are two clues, however, that we might be dealing with two different particles. First, the particle that appears in *wh*-questions does not typically seem to surface as a proclitic with assimilation. Though speaker judgments are fickle, those whom I consulted (4 total) judged examples like (79a) to be odd or less natural compared to other alternatives such as (79b). I have also been unable to find examples similar to (79b) in sources where the orthography transparently reflects the spoken form (e.g., texts from Bowen’s pedagogical grammar).

- (79) a. ??Ano **am**=binili mo?
 what = PV.PERF.buy 2SG(DEP)
 ‘What did you buy?’
- b. Ano=**ng** binili mo?
 what= PV.PERF.buy 2SG(DEP)
 ‘What did you buy?’

When asked to read aloud roughly 10 examples involving *wh*-questions that included *ang* in the written source, speakers produced it variably as (full) *ang* or as [=ŋ], but never produced it as a proclitic (with assimilation) of the following word as in example (79a).

Second, as an enclitic, there is obligatory nasal assimilation to the following word when the particle is used in its function as the marker of a subject. Consider (80).²⁵

²⁵An apparent exception to this involves cases where the vowel of the word immediate preceding *ang* ends in the vowel [a]. In such cases, contraction of *ang* to [=ŋ] is possible, concomitant with placement of stress on the preceding vowel typically realized as compensatory lengthening of that vowel.

- (i) Hindi nag-iiba:=ŋ sabong.
 NEG AV.PERF-change=SUBJ cock-fighting
 ‘Cockfighting is not going to change.’
 (Bowen 1965:356)

- (80) *Bini-binili* {mo:=m/*mo:=ŋ} putubumbong.
 buy you=N/you=ŋ putobumbong
 ‘You are buying the puto-bumbong’ (Bowen 1965:229, elicitation)

Given this, it is perhaps surprising that in interrogatives we very often find an unassimilated form [=ŋ], as this would seem to suggest that the two processes (vowel deletion and assimilation) are not necessarily tied together, as suggested above. The problem can be resolved, however, if we assume that we are dealing with two different morphemes and their different allomorphs. Concretely, suppose that there are two morphemes, one that belongs to the category C, the other belonging to the category D. Common to both is /aŋ/, which may be realized as either [aŋ] or as an enclitic with an assimilated nasal (represented as [=N] below). The C and D particles diverge, however, in that the former but not the latter may be realized by the unassimilated [=ŋ]; and the latter but not the former may be realized as an assimilated proclitic ([aN=]). This is summarized in the table in (81).

(81)	C	D
	{[aŋ], [=N]}	{[aŋ], [=N]}
	[=ŋ]	[aN=]

If this is correct, we might wonder why C (but not D) has the designated [=ŋ] allomorph.²⁶

²⁶A review, presumably citing their own intuitions, claims that example (i) is grammatical, but (ii) is not:

- (i) a. *Sino*{=ŋ/aŋ} *pangulo*?
 who president
 ‘Who is the president?’
 b. **Sino*=ŋ *ang pangulo*?
 who UNM president
 ‘Who is the president?’

The reviewer is correct to point out examples like (iib) as problematic, given that they apparently show complementary distribution between the two *angs* (C and D) that I have proposed. I am not sure, however, how robust the fact reported by the reviewer is. The following examples of copular clauses of the form DP cop DP appeared through web-searches and were found by native speaker consultants to be grammatical:

- (ii) a. *Sino*=ng *ang boses ng bayan*?
 who=C UNM voice DEP people
 ‘Who is the voice of the people?’
 (<https://www.facebook.com/engrberto22/videos/sinong-ang-bose-ang-bayan-sino-ang-handang-lumaban-i-n-d-a-y-s-a-r-a/1596240214775897/>)
 b. *Sino*=ng *ang bayani mo*?
 who=C UNM hero 2SG(DEP)
 ‘Who is your hero?’
 (<https://www.facebook.com/gmapublicaffairs/videos/araw-ng-mga-bayani-i-juander/1308865237416397/>)
 c. *Sino*=ng *ang kasama niya*?
 who=C UNM companion 3SG(DEP)
 ‘Who is his/her companion?’

As it happens, the existence of this allomorph is consistent with its treatment as a complementizer, as [=ŋ] (also referred to as the “linker”) is a common and sometimes obligatory realization of C, as illustrated by the following example from Richards (1999:298)

- (82) Hindi niya sinabi[=ŋ] kinain niya ang tambakol.
 not 3SG(DEP) ACC.PERF.say=C ACC.PERF.eat 3SG(DEP) UNM mackerel
 ‘He didn’t say that he ate the mackerel.’

The complementizer [=ŋ] has an allomorph /na/, which – as far as I have been able to determine – does not surface in *wh*-questions. This may seem a problem for assimilating [=ŋ] in interrogatives with the complementizer. However, as noted in Richards (1999), there are other contexts where – when the conditions for reduction of /na/ to [=ŋ] are met – reduction must occur. One such context that Richards observes, interestingly enough, involves extraction in relative clauses. Specifically, when a relative operator (null, in Tagalog) is extracted leaving a trace in the clause introduced by the complementizer, the complementizer *must* be realized as [=ŋ].²⁷ Consider the following example, from Richards (1999:304).

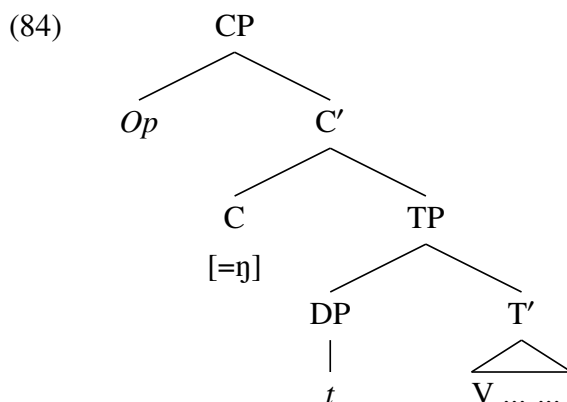
- (83) ang aklat na [VP alam ni Maria [CP Op [=ŋ]/*[na] binabasa t ni Juan]]
 UNM book LK know DEP Maria =C PV.PERF.read DEP Juan
 ‘The book that Maria knows that Juan reads’
 (Richards 1999:304, ex. (23))

According to Richards, the structure for the embedded clause contained within the relative clause would be something like what is shown in (84). In particular, given that extraction is limited to the ‘highest’ structural argument (the subject or topic), we can assume a trace of this element left behind in the highest position within TP or some projection above TP but below C.

(<https://balita.mb.com.ph/2024/05/02/labor-day-message-ni-pbbm-para-sa-bashers-ng-foreign-trips-niya-solon/>)

At this point in time, it is not clear how to reconcile these examples with the ungrammaticality of the reviewer’s. At best, I could speculate that the ungrammaticality of the reviewer’s example might be attributed to some kind of gradient halpology effect, which is stronger in the reviewer’s idiolect compared to speaker’s with whom I have consulted but do not judge them to be as sharply ungrammatical. Plainly, a more detailed investigation is needed here to make a convincing case either way.

²⁷ Apparently, it does not show assimilation effects with the following consonant.



This, of course, is the same structure that I am claiming to be the structure for *wh*-questions as well (expect that the null operator in *wh*-questions is replaced by an overt *wh*-phrase). Relating the the two structures by their connection with the ‘linker’ ($[=\eta]$) provides a simple and unified analysis and thus provides additional support for the claim that *wh*-questions are derived by *wh*-movement (or, at the very least, that this possibility exists even for argument *wh*-questions).

Before moving on, a brief comment is in order concerning the difference between DP argument *wh*-questions (which, utilize the C-morpheme in (81)) and PP argument/adjunct *wh*-questions, as in (72) from above, that apparently do not. To account for this, I propose a context sensitive spell-out rule for C which distinguishes C based on whether it hosts a DP_{wh} argument as its specifier from contexts where it hosts a PP_{wh} , corresponding to an argument or adjunct. Specifically, the rule for spell-out of C in (85).^{28, 29}

(85) *Wh-C Agreement in Tagalog*:

- a. $C[wh] \leftrightarrow \{/(a)\eta/, [=ng]\} / DP_{wh} \text{ in Spec, CP}$
- b. $C[wh] \leftrightarrow \emptyset / PP_{wh} \text{ in Spec, CP}$

While this may seem to be a stipulation, it is important to note that similar types of *Wh-C Agreement* are well preceded in other languages (e.g., in the *que/qui* alternation in French (see Kayne 1976), the *aL/aN* versus *go/gur* alternation in Irish (see McCloskey 1979); and

²⁸This may be an oversimplification, depending on what the category status of questions words like *bakit* (‘why’) and *kailan* (‘when’) are. If we analyze them as PPs (introduced, for instance, by a null preposition), then the rule can be stated as is. On the other hand, if they are DPs or belong to some other category, the rule would need to reflect this – e.g., $DP[-argument]$.

²⁹A review raises the appropriate question of why it should be the case that the ‘complementizer’ of questions should be relatable at all to the case marker for subjects, noting that this is not an idiosyncratic fact about Tagalog but – if I am correct – a very robust fact for many (Western) Austronesian languages. At the present time, I do not have a particularly good answer to this question, apart from noting that overlap between functional elements associated with D and C are not unfounded (e.g., English *that* and as observed in other Germanic languages. Also of note, verbs in at least a subset of *wh*-questions appear to take nominalizing morphology (e.g., as in Chamorro (Chung 1994, 1998), and K’iche’ (Can Pizabaj & Aissen 2021). Nominalization may be a related, in other words, to the use of a determiner-related Complementizer. Further typological research is necessary in order to further pursue these connections and go beyond speculation.

the complementizer alterations in Chamorro (see Chung 1998:221-234). This being the case, while it is true that (85) is a language-internal stipulation, it is placeable in a broader cross-linguistic context involving allomorphy of C conditioned by the categorical properties of the phrase that it hosts as its specifier.

4 Question Semantics: Implications for Pseudo-Cleft Analysis

In this section, I investigate the question of whether, and – if so – to what extent, a pseudo-cleft analysis of *wh*-questions aligns with a standard treatment of *wh*-questions based on the semantic analysis attributed to Hamblin (1973) and Karttunen (1977). Although the semantics of questions continues to be investigated up to the present time (see, e.g., Dayal 2016, Kotek 2018 and references therein), the Hamblin/Karttunen semantics remains, for the most part, the standard semantic analysis. The main conclusion reached here is that applying this analysis to *wh*-questions under a pseudo-cleft analysis requires two stipulations: First, that the *wh*-phrase, which is analyzed as a predicate, must undergo covert or overt movement in order to generate the correct semantics for a questions. In essence, this means that Tagalog must permit a predicate phrase (PredP³⁰) to undergo raising. I will scrutinize this claim in detail in Section 5.2., and ultimately argue that PredP raising is not available in Tagalog. A second implication is that the remainder of the *wh*-phrase, which is analyzed as a subject containing a free relative clause according to the pseudo-cleft analysis, must be interpreted either as an *existential free relative* (Caponigro et. al 2021 (the collection of works therein), Caponigro 2022, Caponigro & Falus 2023) or as a definite DP. As it happens, the latter possibility is what would be expected from a language internal perspective, given that subjects in Tagalog must, in general, be interpreted as definite, as argued for in detail in Collins (2018). However, interpreting the remainder as an existential free relative is the only way to ensure the right semantics for this portion of a *wh*-question, though this entails assigning an interpretation that is at odds with the usual syntax-semantics mapping in the language. Summarizing the argument and to foreshadow the conclusion: A pseudo-cleft analysis for *wh*-questions does not easily fit with the standard semantic analysis of *wh*-questions in general.

4.1 Questions Semantics Requires PredP Raising

We can begin with the semantics for *wh*-questions attributed to Hamblin (1973) and Karttunen (1977).³¹ According to this approach, questions are taken to denote the set of possible answers to the question. As summarized clearly in Dayal (2016, Ch. 1:5-11), a typical

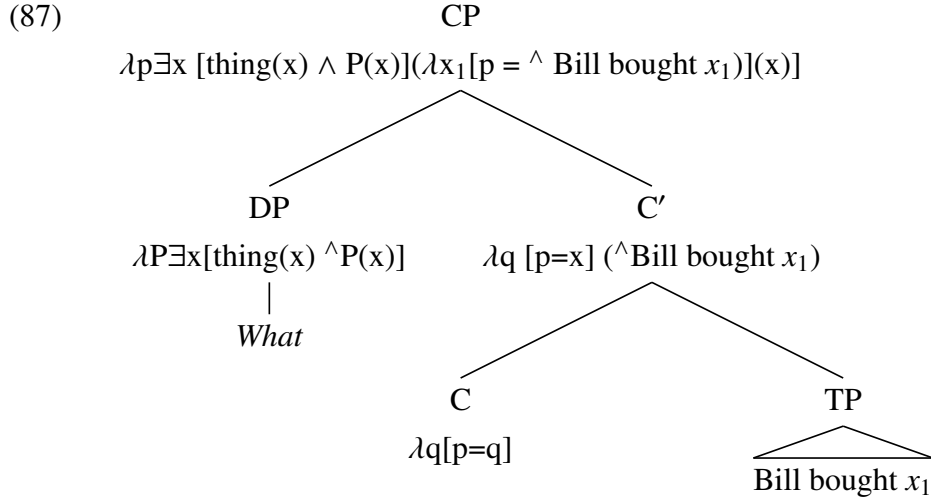
³⁰I am using PredP here as a cover for whatever category is fronted that contains the verb and its arguments. It is not intended, necessarily, to be equivalent to the PredP category of Borer's (1993) and related works.

³¹I thank Vaneeta Dayal for discussing this topic with me during a visit to MIT.

wh-question such as (86) involves three key components from the perspective of the syntax and the semantics.³² There is the TP (*Bill buy t*), $C_{[+wh]}$, and the *wh*-phrase located in CP's specifier, as schematized in (86b). Semantically, TP (=the question nucleus) denotes the proposition *Bill bought x_i* , and $C_{[+wh]}$ is a crucial element that shifts the propositional meaning of its complement from a proposition to a set of propositions, which – as just mentioned – is key to the Hamblin/Karttunen semantics for questions, which takes questions to denote the set of (possible) answers to the question. Finally, the *wh*-phrase is assumed here to be a quantifier, specifically, an existential quantifier.³³ Thus, the syntactic elements in (86b) correspond to the semantic elements shown in (86c).

- (86) a. What did Bill buy?
 b. $[CP [What] [C' C_{[+wh]}-did] [TP Bill buy x]]]$
 c. $[\lambda p \exists x.[thing(x) \vee P(x)]_{whP} [\lambda q[q=p]]_C [(\wedge Bill bought x_1)]_{TP}]$

Each of the elements above combine via function application, as shown in (87).

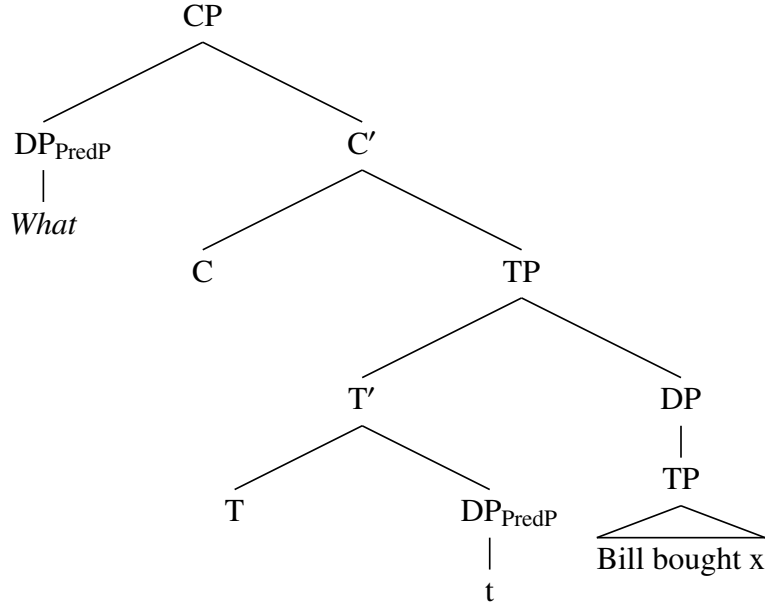


What is crucial here is that the *wh*-phrase has scope above $C_{[+wh]}$. As Dayal (2016:9) states, “If we had the *wh* taking scope inside *p*, we would have: $\lambda p p = \wedge \exists x [book(x) \wedge Bill bought x]$. None of the propositions...determined to be possible answers (i.e., to the question, Author) would past muster.” Concretely, if the *wh*-phrase (the existential quantifier) has its scope below the function $\lambda q[p=q]$, then the only proposition that would qualify as an answer to the question would be *Bill bought some book* rather than, e.g., *{Bill bought War & Peace, Bill bought Emma, etc}*. The implication of this for a pseudo-cleft analysis is this: In order to generate an appropriate semantics for *wh*-questions based on a pseudo-cleft structure, it will be necessary for the *wh*-phrase predicate to undergo movement either overtly or covertly. Assuming this, the structure to be interpreted would be as shown in (88).

³²For a more elaborated view, see Dayal (2026) .

³³In other approaches, the *wh*-phrase is analyzed as a simple property rather than as a (generalized) existential quantifier. See Section 4 for some discussion.

(88)



If the *wh*-phrase remained in the predicate position (as complement of T), it would be able to compose directly with the remainder if (and only if) the remainder is interpreted as an *existential free relative clause* (see Copanigro 2022, et. seq., and Section 4.4 below) of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ (i.e., $\lambda x. \text{Bill bought } x$).³⁴ If so, then continuing to assume that the *wh*-phrase has the interpretation of an existential quantifier will yield the denotation for TP as: $\exists x[\text{thing}(x) \wedge \text{Bill read } x]$. All would be well up to this point, but a problem will arise when $C_{[+wh]}$ is introduced. With $C_{[+wh]}$ scoping above the *wh*-phrase, it will also scope above the existential quantifier introduced by the *wh*-phrase, yielding the undesirable logical form: $\lambda p[p = \wedge \exists x [\text{book}(x) \wedge \text{Bill bought } x]]$. This can be remedied, however, if the *wh*-phrase undergoes movement as illustrated in (88). When moved, it will leave behind a trace which can be assumed to be interpreted as a variable of type $\langle e \rangle$. This can then be composed with the free relative giving the higher TP the denotation: $\wedge \text{Bill bought } x$. The rest of the sentence will compose in the manner already illustrated in (87).

As the analysis here makes use of raising of the predicate phrase (PredP), which – for a pseudo-cleft analysis is the *wh*-phrase – we need to now ask whether this movement is independently motivated. I turn to this question immediately below, concluding that it is not. If the arguments here are sound, this conclusion casts serious doubt on the pseudo-cleft analysis for interrogatives for Tagalog more generally.

4.2 PredP Raising

In a series of works, Postdam (2016, 2017) (see also Paul 2001, Potsdam & Polinsky 2009) have argued for a pseudo-cleft analysis of *wh*-questions in other Austronesian languages such as Malagasy and Fijian. Taking up the question of why many Austronesian languages

³⁴We will return to this in greater detail in Section 5.3.

appear to make use of the pseudo-cleft strategy for forming interrogatives, Potsdam (2009) observes that many of the languages for which a pseudo-cleft analysis of interrogatives is proposed are also verb initial. In addition, for many of these languages (Malagasy, for instance) verb initial word order has been analyzed as being derived by “vP-fronting” – raising of the predicate phrase (PredP) that contains the vP or a remnant of the vP (see, e.g., Aldridge 2002, Pearson 2000, 2017, Massam 2001, Holmer 2005). Based on his observations for Malagasy and a case study of Fijian, Potsdam (2009) argues for the following implication universal.

(89) Universal 12-VP:

If a language uses VP raising to derive V1 word order, then it cannot have *wh*-movement.

Potsdam’s Universal 12-VP is a somewhat stronger form of the generalization proposed by Oda (2002, 2005).

(90) Oda’s Generalization:

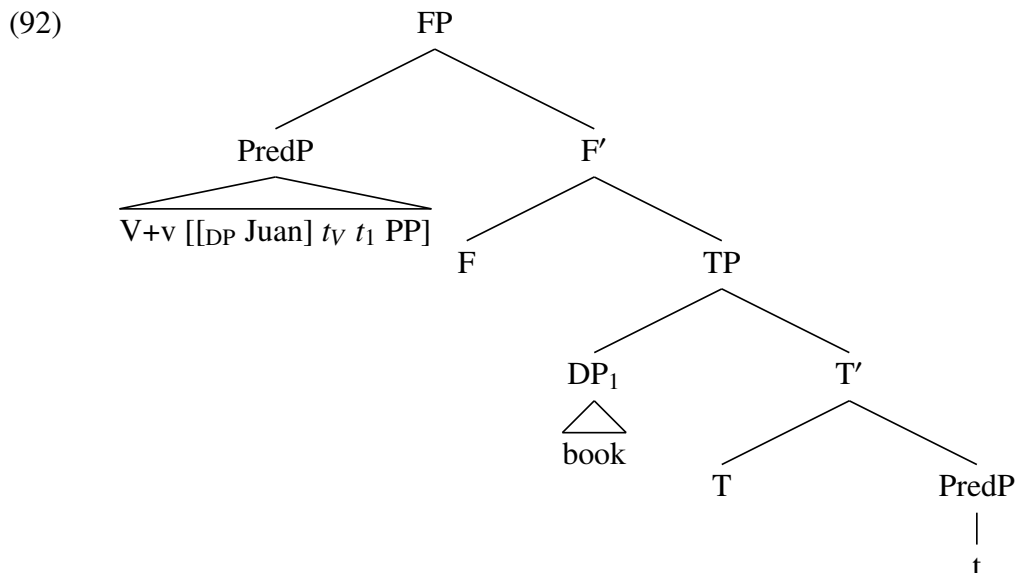
If a language uses VP raising to derive V1 word order, then it will have available a cleft to form *wh*-questions.

Oda’s generalization therefore does not rule out a language that has VP raising to derive V1 but also *wh*-movement to derive its interrogatives. Potsdam’s Universal 12-VP, on the other hand, limits how interrogatives can be formed for a language that also has VP-raising. The question now opens up: Is verb initial word order in Tagalog derived by “VP-raising”? This question is especially pertinent given the claim of the previous section – since PredP raising would seem to be crucial to a pseudo-cleft analysis of interrogatives. In fact, if PredP raising and pseudo-cleft syntax for *wh*-questions are tied together along the lines suggested by Potsdam and Oda, we can begin to see why this would be the case. Concretely, if a language uses PredP raising to derive verb initial order, then it has the mechanism for a *wh*-phrase (as predicate) to move thus generating an appropriate logical form. If PredP raising is not available, on the other hand, it will not.³⁵

How viable, then, is a PredP raising analysis for Tagalog? First, let us sketch out what this would look like. In order to derive a sentence like (91) below, we must assume that what is raised is a constituent that contains the verb and the external argument (in that order), plus any additional arguments or adjuncts associated with the vP. Assuming that the argument that functions as the subject has raised out of this constituent – e.g., to Spec, TP – then the only complication that needs to be added to the picture is that there must be head movement of the verb to the head position of the projection that undergoes raising (PredP, in the trees below; see Travis 2003 on the presence of head-movement within a phrase that undergoes further phrasal movement).

³⁵This way of thinking about the subject is not exactly how either Potsdam or Oda put it, although Oda’s generalization comes closest if we assume the generalization is bi-directional.

- (91) *Binili ni Juan para kay Maria ang aklat.*
 bought Juan for Maria book
 ‘Juan bought the book for Maria.’



While deriving the word order for sentence (91) involves a relatively straightforward fronting of PredP, deriving other possible word orders introduces added complications. Concretely, each of the permutations of the word order in (91) given in (93) are possible.³⁶

- (93) a. *Binili ni Juan **ang aklat para kay Maria.***
 b. *Binili **ang aklat ni Juan para kay Maria.***
 c. *(?)Binili **ang akalat para kay Maria ni Juan.***

In order to derive these word orders, given the assumptions of the PredP raising analysis sketched so far, additional phrasal movement is required. In particular, every phrase (in bold) following the subject (italicized) must be moved out of PredP to a position below the subject prior to movement of PredP. For (93a), for instance, the PP must vacate PredP as schematized in (94a); for (93b), both the PP and the external argument DP must be moved out of PredP prior to PredP fronting, as shown in (94b); and for (93c), the PP and the external argument again must move out of PredP, but in a different order from the order of movement deriving (93b). This is shown in (94c).

- (94) a. $[[[\text{PredP } V+v [\text{DP } t_V t_1 t_{PP}]]_1 [\text{DP}_1 [\textbf{PP } [\text{PredP } t_1]]]]]$
 b. $[[[\text{PredP } V+v [t_2 t_V t_1 t_{PP}]]_1 [\text{DP}_1 [\textbf{DP}_2 [\textbf{PP } [\text{PredP } t_1]]]]]]]$
 c. $[[[\text{PredP } V+v [t_2 t_V t_1 t_{PP}]]_1 [\text{DP}_1 [\textbf{PP } [\textbf{DP}_2 [\text{PredP } t_1]]]]]]]$

³⁶Though some, for some speakers, are more marked than others. For instance, some speakers have a strong preference for the external argument to appear immediately after the verb, while others do not share this intuition. Additionally, while all of the word orders are generally accepted, no study that I am aware of has done a thorough job of testing actual production data showing the relative frequency of the different orders.

Issues quickly become even more complicated when we consider adverbs, where the scope of movement of PredP itself becomes variable with no obvious motivation other than to account for different word orders. Pearson (2000) observes that word order in the Malagasy vP appears to be the opposite of the word order within vP in languages like English. For instance, in Malagasy, the goal follows the theme in double objects but precedes it in English. In Malagasy, specific direct objects occur to the right of adverbials, while non-specific objects occur to the left. This latter fact about word order is contrasted with German, which shows the reverse pattern (specific objects occur to the left of adverbials, nonspecific objects occur to the right).

This *mirror image* effect, Pearson argues, offers an argument for deriving verb initial order in Malagasy by PredP raising (see Pearson 2005, Rackowski 1998, and Travis 2006 for details of this argument). The same argument cannot be made for Tagalog, primarily because Tagalog exhibits a greater flexibility in the position where adverbials surface compared to what is reported in Malagasy. In Malagasy, adverbials appear after the verb. For at least *-ly* type adverbials in Tagalog, these may occur *before* or *after* the verb. When they occur before the verb, they surface with the linker element *na* (allomorph [=ŋ]). Alternatively, these adverbials may appear after the verb (in the unmarked case, at the right periphery of the vP) in which case they are subordinated by the linker-like element *nang*. Consider the following examples.

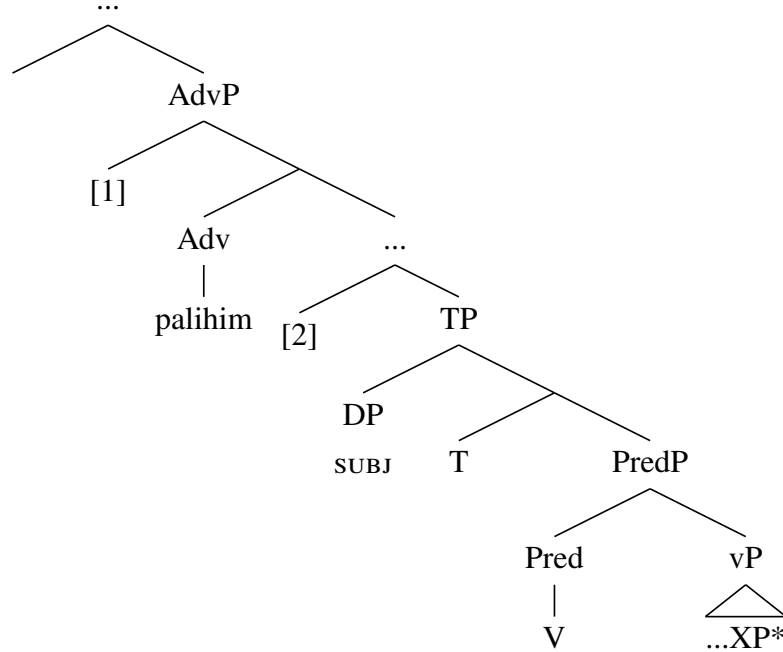
- (95) Palihim siya=ng nag-nakaw ng pera.
secretly 3SG(UNM)=LK AV.PERF-stole DEP money.
'He secretly stole money.'
- (96) Nag-nakaw siya ng pera nang palihim.
AV.PERF-stole 3SG(UNM) DEP money LK secretly
'He stole the money secretly.'

One possible way to account for the two positions of the adverbial in these examples would be, following the model presented in Cinque (1998), to assume that the adverbial is the head of a functional projection AdvP.³⁷ Adopting this idea, we can account for the post-verbal placement of an adverbial by assuming movement of a constituent containing the verb and its arguments to the specifier position of AdvP (indicated as position [1] in the tree in (97) below). When the adverb surfaces to the left of the verb, we can assume that the same projection does not raise as high as Spec, AdvP, but rather that it raises to a position below AdvP, but higher than the subject (indicated as position [2] in the tree in (97)).³⁸

³⁷This is not crucial. We could also assume adjunction to the left or to the right.

³⁸If we allow right specifiers, then – in principle – this movement would not be crucial.

(97)



This analysis is made further complicated by word orders other than those exhibited by examples (98)-(99). For instance, an adverbial introduced by *nang* may precede the external argument in ‘Patient-voice’ sentences.

- (98) Kinuha nang palihim ng asawa ko ang aking bank card
PV.PERF.took LK secretly DEP husband 1SG(DEP) UNM 2SG(OBL).LK bank card
para dalhin ang kanyang kasintahan sa isang biyahe
in.order.to take UNM 3SG(OBL).LK girlfriend LK one.LK trip
‘My husband secretly took my bank card in order to take his girlfriend on a trip.’
(<https://www.facebook.com/profile.php?id=61565069276973>)
Entertainment News Post, Nov. 5, 2025)

The adverbial may also be positioned before a direct object in a ‘Patient-voice’ sentence.

- (99) May naka-pagdate na ba nang palihim ng lalaki bago nag-out?
exist AV.PERF-date PRT Q LK secretly DEP guy before AV.PERF.go.out
‘Is there anyone who has secretly dated a guy before going out (with him)?’
(https://www.reddit.com/r/teenagers/comments/1rjdv0e/has_anyone_ever_secretly_dated_a_guy_before/?tlfil)

Continuing to assume that the presence of the linker element *nang* introduces adverbials with fronted PredPs, in order to derive the word order in (98) we would first need to assume that the external argument is moved out of PredP to a position above the subject, as schematized in (100a). For the word order in (99), it would be necessary to assume that the DP object of the verb *nakapag-date* is first moved out of PredP (possibly, to a position

above the subject) before PredP is raised to the specified position of AdvP, as schematized in (100b).

- (100) a. [AdvP [FP [V kinuha] t_i]_j [Adv palihim] [**ng aking asawa**]_i [GP DP_{subj} G [FP t_j]]]
 b. [AdvP [FP [V nakapag-date] t_i]_j [Adv palihim] [**ng lalaki**]_i [GP (DP_{subj}) G [FP t_j]]]

Plainly, the cost of a PredP fronting analysis for Tagalog is the need for a very unrestricted theory of movement. Each of the movement operations needed to create a remnant PredP is motivated only to account for the different word order permutations that are observed. They are, evidently, completely optional otherwise (i.e., there are no strong pragmatic effects associated with this kind of movement).³⁹ Note that this extends not only to arguments contained within the PredP, but also to the constituent PredP itself, whose landing site would be variable based on the position of adverbs. Again, this aspect of the PredP fronting analysis is motivated solely to provide an adequate description of the observed facts. For a theory of movement based on the idea that specific features are involved in triggering movement (e.g., the *Agree* model proposed in Chomsky 2001), any features proposed would be ad-hoc, and not grounded by any syntactic, semantic, or pragmatic features.⁴⁰

Importantly, it is not just the complexity of this analysis that makes it problematic. One of the main arguments typically cited for the PredP raising analysis comes from the celebrated “Subject only” restriction on extractions in Tagalog and related language (see the brief description in Section 3.4, and references there and below). Descriptively, this restriction is behind the ban on extraction of agent external arguments and theme direct objects when these do not serve as the subject of the clause.⁴¹ Proponents of the PredP raising analysis (see, for instance, Aldridge 2002, and the discussion in Clemens & Polinsky 2018:15-18 and Chung 2005:16-21) cite this restriction as evidence for PredP raising, reasoning that because the relevant arguments are contained within the raised PredP, they are unable to move out of PredP as a general prohibition against extraction from a derived specifier (a “freezing effect”; see Corver 2017 for a survey). This explanation would be invalid here, however. If phrases of various types (the external arguments, all varieties of internal arguments) are able to escape the PredP prior to raising, as seems to be a necessary stipulation to derive the various word order permutations observed, then – all things being equal – these phrases should also be free for subsequent extraction. In other words, they would not be ‘frozen’

³⁹Richards 2013, who describes the word order permutations as scrambling, also demonstrates that this movement lacks effects for binding such as Principle A and weak cross over. As he puts it (2013:430), “scrambling is almost inert; it has effects on word order and creates new binders for Principle C, **but has no effect on any other aspect of interpretation**” (author’s emphasis)

⁴⁰Under the *Agree* model, movement is indirectly tied to some kind of feature matching/agreement through an ‘EPP’ feature. This does not alter the argument of the main text, since it would entail optional and sporadically distributed EPP features, still not tied to any obvious feature of the morpho-syntax or syntax/pragmatics interfaces.

⁴¹See Hsieh 2025 and Pizarro-Guevera & Wagers (2022) for important caveats and exceptions to the condition relating to the external argument.

within the raised PredP.

4.3 Interim Summary

I conclude from this discussion that there are insufficient arguments for deriving verb initial word order in Tagalog by means of VP raising. Given the complexity that such an analysis involves to derive the available word order possibilities, any proposal to derive verb initial word order in this way would need to be justified by strong empirical and theoretical arguments. To my knowledge, the existing literature lacks such arguments.⁴² This, as alluded to above, has implications for the pseudo-cleft analysis of *wh*-questions. Since that analysis requires movement of the PredP in order to derive a coherent semantics for *wh*-questions, if motivation for PredP is lacking in the domain of deriving verb initial word order, it is presumably lacking in the domain of *wh*-questions. I conclude at this point, therefore, that a pseudo-cleft analysis is not the correct analysis of *wh*-questions based on this wider perspective. This conclusion is in line with Potsdam/Oda's generalization concerning the connection between *wh*-questions formation strategies and "vP raising" (=PredP raising).

Note that if the conclusions reached here are sound, they invite a stronger version of Oda/Potsdam's generalizations as a bi-directional. Specifically, the hypothesis that emerges from the discussion so far suggests that a (pseudo-)cleft analysis for *wh*-questions is available for a language if – *and only if* – the language also makes use of PredP-raising. While it is unclear to me whether the 'use' of such a mechanism has to be specifically tied to verb initial word order, for this to be a valid proposal there would need to be some kind of independent evidence within a language for PredP raising to support it (see, e.g., the discussion in Cole & Harmon 2007, and Chung 2008). At this stage, such evidence seems to be lacking for Tagalog.⁴³

4.4 A Further Semantic Problem

Even if it were not for the issue of PredP-raising confronting a pseudo-cleft analysis for Tagalog, there is a further issue relating to the semantics of *wh*-questions that such an analysis faces. This further issue relates to the remainder of the *wh*-question, which – according to the pseudo-cleft analysis – is a DP containing a headless relative clause, which functions as the subject of the clause that has the *wh*-phrase as its predicate. In order to approximate an adequate logical form of a question on a pseudo-cleft analysis, it is necessary to assume that this DP has the interpretation of a property (basically, an indefinite, or something of type $\langle e, t \rangle$). Effectively, this means that the relative clause containing subject in the structure of an interrogative question must be interpreted as a *existential free relative* (to use the terminology of Copanigro 2022, et. seq.). This, as it happens, is precisely what Potsdam

⁴²On Travis and head vs. phrasal movement.

⁴³For additional discussion of deriving verb initial word order in Tagalog, and arguments against PredP-raising, see Sabbagh (2013).

(2007:592-593) assumes to be true for Malagasy for which he argues for a pseudo-cleft structure for interrogatives.⁴⁴

Interpreting the headless relative clause as an existential free relative specifically means not interpreting it as a *maximal free relative* (again, using Copanigro’s terminology). An interpretation as a maximal free relative involves interpreting the (headless) relative clause as a definite DP, which – according to Copanigro (2022) – involves applying an ι -operator to the DP that contains the free relative. This has the effect of type-shifting the relative clause from type $\langle e, t \rangle$ to type $\langle e \rangle$. The final semantic composition of the question involves more detail than is necessary to go into here, but see Potsdam (2007:592-593) for a complete illustration. The question that arises here, then, is whether it is viable to claim – under a pseudo-cleft analysis – that the subject which contains the free relative clause can indeed be interpreted as an existential free relative. Importantly, this claim runs counter to the prevailing claim that subjects in Tagalog must be specific (according to Rackowski 2002) or, perhaps more accurately, definite (see, e.g., Collins 2019).⁴⁵ More concretely, the literature on interpretation of noun phrases in the Tagalog clause has reached a more or less broad consensus that subjects cannot be interpreted as simple indefinites (i.e., as simple properties). To illustrate with an example similar to one provided by Collins (2019:1374), consider example (101).

- (101) Sinabi ni Juan na huli ang guro, ngunit maaga ang guro.
 PV.PERF.SAY DEP Juan C late UNM teacher however early UNM teacher
 ‘Juan said that the teacher was late, but (s)he (=the teacher) was early.’

In this minimal discourse for which it is assumed that the context of the utterance remains the same, the referent of *ang guro* (‘teacher’) is identical. This is to be expected if the subject here is interpreted as definite, assuming that there is a uniqueness requirement (relative to context) attached to definite interpretations for noun phrases. Compare (101) with (102) below, where the bare noun phrase *guro* serves as the pivot of an existential predicate. For this example, there is a strong intuition that there are two different teachers being talked about. This is to be expected if the pivot here denotes a mere property (i.e., $\lambda x.\text{teacher}(x)$) by virtue of the fact that it serves as the ‘pivot’ of the existential predicate (see, for example, Sabbagh 2009). Since the DP here simply introduces a property, nothing in particular would sway a hearer to assume that the same individual is involved. Further, the intuition that there are two separate individuals presumably falls out from the general fact that indefinites are used to introduce new discourse referents (rather than to refer to a unique and possibly familiar referent). The use of two indefinite DPs in a single minimal discourse therefore is likely to be felicitous only when each indefinite introduces its own new discourse referent.

⁴⁴According to Potsdam’s analysis of Malagasy, the predicate *wh*-phrase of the pseudo-cleft also undergoes movement. For him, this movement is not necessarily motivated by the semantics, but instead follows according to the view that PredP raising is the basic mechanism for generating predicate initial word order in the language. It is also independently needed to account for sluicing in Malagasy.

⁴⁵They may also be quantificational. See Collins (2019) for details.

- (102) Mayroo=ng guro=ng huli, at mayroo=ng guro=ng maaga.
 exist.there=LK teacher=LK late and exist.there=LK teacher=LK early
 ‘There was a teacher who was late and there was a teacher who was early.’

In short, (bare) noun phrases that are marked by *ang* are routinely interpreted as definite, according to the observations made by numerous other scholars of the language. If this is indeed correct, then the problem for the pseudo-cleft analysis should be clear: Since the *ang* plus the remainder (=the headless relative clause) is a subject according to the pseudo-cleft analysis, it ought to be subject to the same restrictions of other *ang*-marked subjects and be interpreted as definite rather than as a property (i.e., as type <e> rather than type <e,t>). The problem here is at least two-fold: First, if the *wh*-phrase has the type of a quantifier, then – as a predicate – a subject of type <e> would be the wrong type to compose with it. We might abandon the assumption that the *wh*-phrase is a quantifier and assume, alternatively, that it has a property denotation (type <e,t>), following Rooth (1992, Beck & Kim 2006, Cable 2010, Kotek 2018). A problem still remains, however, in that if the remainder is interpreted as a definite DP, there should be a presupposition of existence (and presumably as well, uniqueness) associated with it. This does not seem to be correct for Tagalog (or for Malagasy, as noted in Potsdam 2007:593). Although questions do typically elicit answers, this is not a requirement for grammaticality. Consider the following dialogue:

- (103) a. M: Nasaan ka?
 where you
 ‘Where were you?’
 b. J: Pumunta ako sa tindahan.
 PERF.AV.go 1SG(UNM) LOC store
 ‘I went to the store.’
 c. M: Ano ang binili mo?
 what PERF.UV.buy 2SG(UNM)
 ‘What did you buy?’
 d. J: Wala/ila=ng sapatos.
 nothing/some=LK shoes
 ‘Nothing/some shoes.’

Note that the answer to question (103c) can either be nothing or a non-empty answer (e.g., some shoes). If questions were associated with a presupposition of existence, then an answer of *wala* (‘nothing’) should be infelicitous. Since it is not, we can conclude that there is no presupposition of existence for interrogative questions like (103c). More broadly, we can conclude that the remainder portion of an interrogative questions is not embedded in a free relative clause that functions as the subject. This is because whatever forces subjects to be definite in general should apply to pseudo-cleft structures (of interrogatives) as well.⁴⁶

⁴⁶As a final effort to make the semantics of *wh*-questions work out, one might assume that both the free relative and the *wh*-phrase are of type <e,t>, that the free relative “subject” is not restricted by the definiteness condition on subjects, and that the two are combined by some kind of predicate modification. For this to work,

5 Conclusion

A topic that I have left out of the present discussion is the analysis of focus constructions like (104), which – according to many authors – have a pseudo-cleft structure.

- (104) Si Mama ang kumain ng mami.
UNM Mama AV.PERF.eat DEP noodle
'Mama is the one who ate the noodles.'
(Nagaya & Hwang 2018:376)

Since I have not investigated this construction in detail, I assume with others that a pseudo-cleft structure is correct for them, or rather – at the very least – acknowledge this as possibly correct. This raises the question: If Tagalog has a pseudo-cleft structure available (for sentences like (104)), and it also has *wh*-movement (for questions of non-DP arguments), what could possibly preclude a pseudo-cleft analysis for *wh*-questions? The arguments in Section 3 are somewhat equivocal here as they primarily demonstrate that there are certain questions (those with possessor *wh*-phrases, those with TAM-words, those with certain allomorphs of /ang/) that a pseudo-cleft analysis does not provide an account of. Still, there are also cases where there might be a true syntactic ambiguity. What would rule out a pseudo-cleft analysis, for example, of very simple *wh*-questions like (105)?

- (105) Sino ang kumain ng mami.
who AV.PERF.eat DEP noodle
'Who ate the noodles?'
(Nagaya & Hwang 2018:376)

The question is more equivocally answered in Section 4, where it was argued that as a predicate the *wh*-phrase would have to undergo PredP-raising in the derivation of a *wh*-question like (105), but PredP-raising is unavailable in general. Would this not also preclude a pseudo-cleft analysis of sentences like (104)? While this is a large enough question that I cannot provide a complete answer, I believe the answer is that it would not. Given the translation of (104) (based on work by Nagaya & Hwang 2018), sentence (104) is interpreted as a specificational clause which might also be characterized as equative in nature. The initial DP, *si Mama* is interpreted as a individual (modulo any type shifting, as type <e>). The second DP (assuming it is a DP) seems to be interpreted as a definite that sets up a variable: *the x that ate the noodles*. Semantically, the initial DP supplies the value for the variable (*Mama is the x that ate the noodles*). Crucially, if there is any movement involved in the derivation of (104), it is not obvious that the movement would be movement of anything other than an individual denoting DP (i.e., it is not PredP-raising). By contrast, the *wh*-phrase in (105) does not denote an individual (it is a quantifier or a property), and

it would have to be assumed that there is some kind of default existential clause above C_[+wh], an assumption which is somewhat at odds with the literature which typically has existential closure operating low in the structure (closer to vP). I will not consider this possibility further, leaving it open for unconvinced reader to pursue.

the remainder of the *wh*-question appears to have the interpretation of a property. Thus, as argued above, the derivation of (105) does involve raising of something of a higher (predicative) type (i.e., PredP-raising), which seems not to be an available mechanism for the grammar of the language.

To put these considerations into a sharper focus, Nagaya & Hwang (2018:378) make the interesting observation that clauses like (104) (in which an agent is the focus) provide the most natural answers to questions like (105). A response with a canonical VSO word order (*Kumain si Mama ng mami*) is infelicitous. This is just to say that while it may be tempting to equate focus constructions and *wh*-questions from a syntactic and semantico-pragmatic perspective, the constructions in fact have rather different pragmatic profiles relating to question-answer congruence suggesting that the (pseudo-)cleft structure, if it is valid for sentences like (104), are different enough from *wh*-questions that equivalent syntactic structure cannot be assumed solely on the basis of similarity in surface forms.

Of course, the topics raised above warrant more in-depth investigation that can be offered here, and I therefore will leave them for now and move on to summarize the main contributions of this paper. This paper has attempted to present a variety of arguments that, contrary to the standard treatment, *wh*-questions in Tagalog are derived by *wh*-movement. This includes not only *wh*-questions involving non-arguments, but for argument DPs as well. The analysis provides a coherent and direct account for the variety of facts presented in Section 3, which proved in one way or another difficult for a wholesale analysis involving a pseudo-cleft analysis. Furthermore, the *wh*-movement analysis provides a coherent and direct analysis that comports with the standard semantic analysis of them – i.e., the Hamblin/Kamp analysis. In the context of the semantic side of *wh*-questions, we argued that a pseudo-cleft analysis could be paired with the standard semantics as long as the *wh*-phrase predicate undergoes movement. From a syntactic perspective, this means that there is *wh*-movement yielding the surface structure, but that this movement differs from ordinary *wh*-movement in that the movement occurs as a result of a more generalized movement rule that targets a predicate phrase (PredP). It was argued then, that such movement has no independent justification outside of its presumptive role of constructing a logical form for *wh*-questions consistent with the Hamblin/Kamp theory. In other words, where one might find independent evidence for PredP raising – in deriving verb initial word order – such evidence is lacking for Tagalog.

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